She-Ra and the Princesses of Power - The Third Child. BOOK 2: Firestorm

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38345230.

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), He-Man and the Masters of the Universe

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Catra (She-Ra) & Original Male Character(s), Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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by DozenthTurmoil

Summary

As the war escalates, the Esoteric god known as Apophis makes his moves. Revelations are unleashed and a kingdom unlike anything Etheria has ever witnessed is born.

Prologue: Nightmares



Prologue

Nightmares

A few months had passed since the Battle of Brightmoon, since so much blood was spilled upon those fields. Adora was getting barely any sleep, just enough to function at the bare minimum. Was it stress? Staying up too late? At least those could be explained, sadly it wasn't. It was the nightmares, the horrid nightmares.

She would often wind up waking up with terrified sobs which carried out long into the night. Glimmer tried to give her as much support as she could, but try as she might, not even she could relieve such nightmares from Adora. They weren't just dying down, no, they were getting *worse* .

The one she is experiencing right now, this one was the worst. This nightmare was the pinnacle of her fears and nightmares all condensed together. In this nightmare she wakes up in the plains outside of Brightmoon, the winds were whipping her and the skies were twisted into a monstrous hurricane in which she was in its dreaded eye. No signs of animals can be seen. There were massive thunderous booms combined with crackles of golden lightning, all making for a dreadful scene. No Sunlight is able to pierce the storm as darkness was all around her.

Adora hastily got to her feet and tried to call out to anyone who would listen but her voice was silenced by the storm. Then...then

she saw those eyes. Massive red serpentine eyes locked onto her, they grew closer as a massive kilometre long golden six-limbed cobra emerged from the storm. Adora could feel her heart race as she gazed upon the massive beast, who commanded the storm as easily as it breathed. Adora's eyes became pinpricks as the great serpent began to smile at her and speak, its voice carried along the storm, making the beast's voice surround her all at once.

"Adoooooraaaaaaaaaaaa" The creature would say, as it drew closer, effortlessly levitating over the vast plains. Its mouth would open, revealing razor sharp teeth the size of houses and a maw filled with crackling golden lightning, its tongue went over each and every one of its teeth.

Adora tried to pull out her sword but couldn't find it. "She-Ra cannot harm the one who commands her, the one who created her in the first place" The golden serpent said with a hiss before unleashing a massive blast of golden lightning from its cavernous maw.

Adora ran and barely missed the explosion but was flung forward and she tumbled down a rocky hill and into a boulder. Adora could feel bloody cuts open up all over her body, her ribs cracked against the boulder. Blood dripped from her red-stained mouth, she could only watch as the serpent took its time getting closer. The serpent opened its maw and wrapped its tongue around Adora, she struggled but couldn't break free as she was dragged closer...and...closer. Until the maw closed down on her and she was crushed against the teeth in such sheer agony.

Adora woke up from the dream, screaming like a banshee. She was drenched in cold sweat and desperately checked her body for the wounds that didn't actually exist, crying all the while. The

doors to her room burst open as Glimmer rushed over to her and hugged her, Glimmer was accompanied by a couple guards.

Adora hugged Glimmer tightly, crying into her shoulder the whole time. “Shhh shh Adora...Adora…” Glimmer gently said as she hugged her tightly and stroked her hair.

“It’s okay...it’s okay” she continued “It was only a dream” Glimmer said, waiting for Adora to calm down. Glimmer felt the ache in her heart seeing the one she loved suffering such nightmares, she wanted to help as much as she could. “Can…can you tell me what it was about?” Glimmer asked softly.

Adora wiped her eyes a bit and looked up, her throat was dry and raw, like it had been dragged through sand and gravel. Adora tried to speak but only wound up in a fit of coughs for her trouble. Glimmer looked at a guard and motioned him to get her some water. “Just take a drink and just talk okay.” Glimmer softly said.

The Guards, seeing that there was no need for their presence, left the princess and her knight alone in the gentle quiet and dark calmness of the bedroom. Adora drank so much and so quickly of the water she found herself gasping for air after drinking her fill.

“It…was the giant snake thing again” Adora muttered softly, Glimmer hugged Adora gently. This was far from the first time Adora had nightmares of this snake. Glimmer knew this had something to do with that Apophis monster that her aunt has been obsessing over as of late, but she didn’t know all the details about it.

“Y-you weren’t there…n-no one was. It was just me and that horrid THING!” Adora said, trembling as Glimmer hugged her close. Glimmer sighed softly, “do you want me to spend the night with you?” she asked Adora, looking into those wonderful grey-blue eyes of hers. Adora nodded “please, just for tonight” Adora softly said.

Glimmer held her close as they both drifted off to sleep. This time, there were no nightmares to haunt Adora…it would be the first time in a long time that she didn’t have such horrific dreams.

Chapter 1: The Expedition

Chapter 1

The Expedition

The cold wind flowed over the snow capped stones of the Shadow Mountains. These icy black stone mountains are Etheria's most ancient formations, no one knows who or what dwells within these primordial lands. Entrapta had found a signal emanating from a location within the largest of the Shadow Mountains, Gor Magara. Gor Magara predates the arrival of the First Ones and their gods, ancient legends surround them...none of them are pleasant.

Still the prospect of ancient technology that had somehow awoken was too big to simply pass up. Hordak ordered an expedition from his two new force commanders, Catra and Gareth. The two began preparing for the expedition, along with their squad. Gareth went to visit Entrapta in her new dedicated workshop, she was happily humming to herself and working quietly.

Gareth smiled softly, it seemed like she's enjoying her new life here. He tapped the metal doorframe with the back of his knuckles which produced a gentle clanging sound. "Hey 'Trapta" Gareth called out with a soft smile.

Entrapta turned around and smiled excitedly, lifting up her visor to fully look at him. "Gareth! I was just working on something for you" she said excitedly "oh, before I tell you about that, did you get the briefing I told Hordak to give to you?" she added with a smile.

Gareth nodded gently “I sure did, hence why I'm getting our team together. Now what’s this thing you are working on?” he added with a raised eyebrow.

Entrapta smiled and, with her hair, picked up a large triple barreled gun. “It’s a handheld, break-action, triple-barreled shotgun. I know you don’t like those energy weapons all too much, so I went ahead and made a combustion-based shotgun for you.

I can even make you ammo for it, like special ammo!” she said with a giggle as Gareth took the shotgun and examined it, moving it around in his hands so that he can get a good feel for its weight. It also had a fearsome pair of bayonets jutting from the mid-section of the gun, the bayonets looked almost like meathooks.

“Thanks ‘Trapta. I appreciate it” Gareth said before he put on its holster around the back of his hip and placed the shotgun in it. “Now come on, we got an expedition to go on!” he said before head patting Entrapta while giving off one of his friendly smiles.

“Gareth, uhm...you know I'm...eh nevermind” Entrapta said, about to give the info that Gareth’s actually younger than her but she didn’t want to burst his bubble. She simply smiled as he walked off, leaving her to quickly finish up her current work and get herself ready for the journey.

Gareth went to the barracks where Catra was assembling the group for the expedition ahead. Gareth wrapped his arms around

his beloved feline wife “there’s my beautiful ray of sunshine” he said kissing her furry cheek. “How’s my asskicking Kit Kat?” Gareth asked with a warm smile.

Catra purred softly “honeeeey, you don’t have to tell me how awesome I am” she said teasingly and kissing her husband on the lips before she looked at the others, who were all smiling and giggling. “Oh come now, it’s not like Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio are all doing it” she said with a smug smirk

The trio instantly blushed hard and had a panicked look. “Uhhhhh” Kyle said, trying to think of a comeback. Catra blushed under her fur along with Gareth and Scorpia. “Holy fuck! You guys really are?!” Catra said with a laugh.

Kyle blushed and rubbed the back of his head “y-yeah we are” he muttered. Scorpia gave the trio a hug as Gareth smiled “well i’m glad you guys are. No judging from me” he said with a wink

Lonnie, still blushing, nodded as she was uncharacteristically nervous about this “th-thanks boss” she softly said before saluting. Entrapta walked into the room handing everyone furry coats. “The Shadow Mountains and Gor Magara are extremely cold! So I went ahead and requisitioned some excellent winter gear and made sure that they all fit each and every one of us” she said with a happy smile.

“I’ll go get Savvi all fired up” Gareth said with a smile, to which Catra sighed with a half lidded smirk. “You already named the tank that Hordak gave us huh?” she said with a raised eyebrow. Gareth, of course, grinned in his usual manner. “I sure did!” he said before walking out and towards the vehicle bay.

Gareth walked past the prison and stopped in his tracks. He walked backwards a little bit and gazed out into the vast place. Gareth could just barely see Shadow Weaver in her cell from where he was standing. He stood there for a few moments wondering if she could see him too, he sighed and kept walking towards the vehicle bay.

Gareth climbed into the Tank and began turning on the systems which whirred to life from his button presses. He turned on the Tank's sensors and cameras, which gave him visual feeds of the area around him before he pulled a lever and the rear troop hatch of the Tank opened up, forming a ramp into the Tank itself.

Catra, Scorpia, The Trio and Entrapta all climbed up into the Tank. Gareth looked over his shoulder and smiled "everyone on board?" he said, sounding like a warrior about to lead his troops into battle. Everyone nodded "Ready Boss!" Scorpia said and Catra got into the co-pilot seat and held Gareth's hand, the two exchanged looks before they drove out of the Fright Zone.

Chapter 2: Here's To The Fallen

Chapter 2

Here's To The Fallen

Glimmer would walk outside of Brightmoon and onto the battle scarred plains that surround her home. She took some hope, seeing that the land was healing from the horrid Battle for Brightmoon. Thanks to Perfuma, it was healing even more, but sightseeing wasn't on her agenda for today. In the long months since that fateful and bloody conflict, Adora had been busy collecting the helmets and blades of every fallen brightmoon soldier that gave their lives during the battle.

Given how many families kept the weapons and helmets, and the fact that they still haven't identified the bodies of most of the fallen given the Horde's laser weaponry, it was easier said than done. Still Adora was determined to perform this task. Glimmer would see Swift Wind fly over her carrying a helmet and sword in his mouth, she followed Swift Wind knowing that he was headed towards Adora.

It was a longer trip than Glimmer expected as it took her to the Whispering Woods. Stepping over roots and other obstacles until she came across a large clearing where Adora was kneeling in front of a vast array of brightmoon weapons, each one topped by a brightmoon helmet. But more than that, she recognized this clearing.

Swift Wind landed beside Adora and dropped the helmet and sword gently onto the ground, making a soft thud in the soft blue grass. “Here you go, Adora, the last one” he said gently. Adora smiled and hugged his snout, gently petting him before setting the sword into the ground and placing the helmet on top.

“Adora...is this…” Glimmer’s voice trailed off as she gazed at how well the swords and helmets were lined up. Each of the helmets and blades were lined up in neat rows and columns, like they were in formations. Adora looked over her shoulder at Glimmer and sighed gently “yeah, this is the clearing where I found She-Ra’s sword...where we first met. It’s probably the most fitting place, all things considered.” Adora explained, looking over her shoulder at the memorial.

Glimmer took in the sight, seeing the many helmets and knowing each one belonged to an individual soldier, an individual who had hopes and dreams...it brought her a grim reminder that this was war. *They were at war* . She looked up and gently stroked Adora’s cheek “Adora it’s okay it’s-” Glimmer was cut off by Adora

“It’s not! We lost so many lives! Netossa lost her leg! A-and it’s all my fault” Adora seethed through clenched teeth, collapsing onto her own knees and letting the tears roll off her face and onto the ground. “I-I wanted them to join us! I thought there was good in them! … I thought…” Adora sobbed, her voice trailing off into more depressive sobs

Glimmer hugged her tightly and started stroking her hair. “It’s not your fault” she whispered. After a few minutes of crying, Adora finally got her resolve back and she stood up. Adora stood up and looked over at the memorial she made, she dried her eyes with her sleeve. “Next time I see them both...they're dead” she snarled slowly.

Glimmer walked closer to Adora “Adora, that’s not you. You’re better than that!” Glimmer said, looking Adora in the eyes, even as Adora herself was focused on looking at the memorial. “That’s the old you talking, the one before you decided to turn your life around. Please don’t think that way, okay?” Glimmer said, trying her best to be a supportive Girlfriend. Far from the bratty princess she once was, Glimmer has been trying to change along with Adora.

They’ve both been helping each other throughout this, and Glimmer hopes they’ll still be together even when everything is over. Adora sighed and held Glimmer close “I-I’m sorry…you’re right. It just makes me so angry to see all of this destruction, knowing who is responsible, and…trying to forgive them.” Adora explained, as if trying to justify her own actions. Actions that Glimmer already knows all about.

“I know, My mom once told me it’s far easier to destroy rather than rebuild. Easier to hate than forgive. Mom also says that is how we should be different from the Horde. We make ourselves above them…I know it’s not much to say that but-”

Glimmer’s was cut off by Adora lifting up her chin and the blonde smiled happily. “You always know just what to say Glimmer” Adora said softly, to which Glimmer blushed. Glimmer looked away a bit and smiled a bit “well I mean…” she started before Adora kissed her right on the forehead.

The two shared a moment before they looked at the monument. “You did something good, I know we can’t bring them back but

we can save everyone else. We can avenge the fallen, we can save Etheria" Glimmer said, holding Adora's hands closely. Adora nodded gently "yeah, I guess so" she said gently.

Glimmer looked around and picked up a small flower, setting it in front of the foremost helmet on the memorial. "Here's to the fallen, may they never be forgotten" Glimmer said softly. Adora could only think of how many more flowers will be placed there in the dark years to come. But Glimmer was right, now was not the time to ponder about what has happened, but to move on and fight more for the freedom of everyone.

Chapter 3: Tomb Of Sins

Chapter 3

Tomb of Sins

The Shadow Mountains, the very crown of the world. Its ancient peaks were not welcoming to the explorers who came from the Horde. Catra could feel the icy cold winds flow through her fur and mane, even with a full blown body covering, she could feel the cold gnaw on her bones. Her boots crunched under the snow as she wiped the snow off the signal tracker's small screen, it hummed rhythmically like a mechanical heartbeat as it pointed the path forward. Catra looked over her shoulder and pulled down the cloth keeping her face warm. "We're almost there guys! Keep moving!" she yelled out to them as she looked forward and kept walking.

Gareth hated the cold, this was a known fact to the group. From the stories of madness brought on by being too cold, from the cold literally causing your limbs to rot away and the slippery ice...there wasn't much that was really inviting about the ice which also appealed to Gareth. His green eyes could barely pierce the icy fog that the winds were conjuring, he looked over his shoulder to see if the rest of the squad was still intact.

Entrapta was holding tightly with her hair onto Emily, Gareth was not sure if she did it to make sure she didn't fall off or to make sure Emily didn't freeze on the spot. Scorpia was rather strong willed and the cold didn't seem to bother her that much, she kept her held up high and kept a well organized march that reflected her pleasant and cheerful mood. The Trio, that being Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio, were keeping quiet but also close together. Gareth muttered to himself "I wish Savvi could make the trip up

here...damn narrow paths” he muttered as he kept a firm pace as he made it up the path.

Catra held onto the Device tightly as she kept walking. In the distance she could see what at first appeared to be a crevice that was shielded from the bitter storms and winds. As she and the group drew closer, she could see that it was indeed a cave. She looked over her shoulder “guys! There’s a cave! We can get some shelter there!” she called out as the others looked up at her.

Definitely their pace quickened, though of course they made sure that they wouldn’t fall off and tumble into the icy cavern below. Once they entered the cave, they felt immediate relief from the cruel storm that howled outside. It was certainly dark inside the cave, Gareth gazed out and could just barely see the sun sink in the distance.

“It’s getting dark out, we should make camp here.” Gareth said as he pulled out some supplies to make a firepit, along with some wood that was, thankfully, dry due to some well placed packaging inside his backpack. Gareth pulled out a lighter and tried to light the fire, he muttered angrily as it wouldn’t ignite properly.

The group decided to stick close as they couldn’t see a thing in this cave, it was dark and very deep. They only stayed close to the mouth due to the available light which provided some visibility, though this visibility was severely lessened as the Moons of Etheria appeared in the sky.

Entrapta slowly touched the cold floor of the cave, mainly because she found it odd that there would be such a perfectly carved out cave all the way out here. Entrapta’s eyes would widen as she kept touching the floor, the floor of the cave was-

Entrapta’s train of thought was interrupted when Gareth

successfully lit the fire and everyone could see the cave fully. The cave floor was paved much like a road, the walls decorated with hieroglyphs and runes which were carved into the walls of the cave. In the distance, just at the edge of the light provided by the fire, The team could just make out the edges of a massive pair of doors, twice the size of Scorpia.

"Well...that's not fucking omnious" Lonnie muttered, half amazed and half horrified beyond all reason. Kyle didn't say a word and Rogelio was stunned by the sight presented before him. Scorpia kept herself close but can only mutter "creeepy...very creepy" while trembling.

Entrapta looked upon the walls and to her surprise "Guys...these aren't First Ones writings. This is something older." she mused, trying to make sense of what she was seeing. She eventually found some First Ones writing, seared unto the ancient metal doors, her fascination swiftly turned into horror.

"Entrapta? What's it say?" Gareth said, noticing her reaction. Entrapta shuddered hard, as if the words made her colder than the storm outside, " *Death Sleeps Here* " she said, tracing the words with one of her hair arms. This entire time Catra's eyes were frantically darting between the device and the ancient doors.

The Device was tracing the signal, and it was beyond those ancient doors…

Chapter 4: The God Serpents

Chapter 4

The God Serpents

Adora stood at the gate that leads into the Crystal Castle. She can recall the painful memory of Catra trying to kill her, dropping her and letting her fall into a pit. She was lucky that Light Hope was able to heal her broken bones.

But this was not why she was here. Adora came for answers, and she wasn't going to leave until she got some. Hopefully these nightmares will end once she found the answers she was looking for. Adora took a deep breath and exhaled. "Eternia" she said sternly, the gate obeyed and slowly opened up towards her.

Adora entered the gleaming fortress without another word, she looked all around herself as her footsteps echoed all around her. It was still as intimidating and cold as ever. Adora sighed softly "Light Hope, I know you're here. I have questions" she said, glaring softly.

Light Hope appeared as the Castle lit up, turning from being engulfed into a grave-like darkness and into a brightly lit citadel. Adora had to cover her eyes a bit to make sure she wasn't completely blinded by the sudden burst of light.

"Hello Adora" Light Hope said in her usual, emotionless voice. "What can I help you with today?" she asked, maintaining eye contact with Adora the entire time. Adora cleared her throat and made sure that she got her thoughts organized.

"I have questions, something that only you could possibly answer." Adora explained, for some reason she felt like she was going to get answers that she would be unprepared to comprehend.

This caught Light Hope's Attention. "Oh? And what kind of questions are those?" she asked, one of her holographic eyebrows being raised, though her tone of voice remained the same.

"I wish to know about a golden snake that is haunting my nightmares and a name that my brother mentioned to Castaspella. I wanna see if there's any connection between the two" Adora explained.

Light Hope seemed...pleased by the idea of a golden snake. But she maintained composure. "And what name did Gareth mention?" she asked. Adora maintained eye contact and made sure she was heard loud and clear. "Apophis" she said with a clear-cut tone of voice.

Light Hope's eyes went wide for a few seconds, seconds that Adora could easily tell were full of fear. "Lord Apophis has awoken?!" she shouted in a disturbingly blissful exclamation. Adora now had even more questions "Light Hope! Who is that?!" she yelled.

“The snake from your dreams is the same being that Gareth mentioned. A God Serpent, one of the 5 Lords of Creation. They ruled the First Ones and were strict masters” Light Hope explained coldly. “I was gifted with this knowledge as She-Ra was a servant of their will, in countless ways. Thus I was designated to train each one of them”

Adora was taking a lot of this in, but it was shocking to her all the same. “Wait, then who are the other 4? Are they here on Etheria?” she asked, wondering if Apophis may have woken up his other siblings.

Light Hope, much to Adora’s relief, shook her head. “They are slumbering upon worlds that are distant from Etheria” Light hope shifted her eyes upward, as if she was double checking if that was still true. “But I will tell you of each the God Serpents” Light Hope said waving her hand to reveal the holograms of 5 crystals, each one being 10 feet in height.

The central one was blue, the ones to the right were gold and green. To the left of the central one was white and next to that one was a crystal that was both red and cyan. Light Hope approached the hologram of the central crystal, it shimmered like the deep oceans.

Light Hope tapped the hologram of the crystal, the sounds of the deep ocean were heard as shadows leaked from the crystal like waterfalls and the image of a great blackish-blue Eel-like serpent with 6 clawed limbs appeared overhead who bears fearsome golden eyes that lack pupils, giving him an even more nightmarish appearance, like that of a deep sea beast. Thanks to the simulatory nature of the castle, it was able to properly render the full size of this creature. Being a whole kilometre in length, much like how Apophis appears in her dreams.

“This is Othaalok, the eldest of the God Serpents and the leader of the pantheon. His domains of magic are Oceans and Darkness. Though in truth, he can manipulate any liquid in any way he desires, he primarily is associated with oceans. The First Ones often pray to him for secure nights and safe journeys across oceans and even the stars.” Light Hope explained before the hologram of Othaalok disappeared. She then went through the others one by one.

Light Hope tapped her fingers upon the white crystal, which gleamed like a precious gem and shimmered like a mirror as the sound of orchestral harps echoed through the air. A beautiful feathered serpent with the same limbs and proportions as Othaalok and Apophis. Her beautiful white scales shimmered like hundreds of mirrors, her serpentine mouth possessed a beak and her countless feathers all had a slight pink hue to them, suffice to say she was an awe to behold even in a simulated form.

“This is Luminatris, the youngest of the God Serpents. Her Domains are Light and Energy. The First Ones regarded her as their guiding light. Her presence alone is what fuels the First Ones' need for exploration and colonization, all the way from their homeworld of Eternia” Light Hope explains. Adora suddenly looked at Light Hope with wide eyes.

“Eternia…is the homeworld of the First Ones?!” Adora shouted to which Light Hope nodded. “It’s where you also came from”. Adora had already known she was an First One ages ago…but this… made her question even more. But while she was contemplating this maddening revelation, Light hope was already onto the Red and Cyan crystal as soon as Luminatris’ hologram had faded away.

Light Hope's touch upon the crystal brought forth intense heat and cold surging from the crystal and a half-molten half-frozen viper while the sounds of wardrums were heard. This monstrous figure radiated violence, even her simultaneous frozen and molten gaze showed nothing more but the death of those that opposed her. Her face was fixed into a permanent furious glare.

"This is Igniatrix, who commands the domains of fire and ice. She is the First Ones Goddess of War and-" Light hope was cut off by Adora. "Why not call them Eternians? They come from Eternia, so let's call them eternians?" Adora said, rubbing the bridge of her nose with her index finger and thumb.

"Very well." Light hope said "This is Igniatrix, who commands the domains of Fire and Ice. She is the Eternians goddess of war and violence. The Eternians often praised her for glory in battle and the slaughter of those who opposed them" she explained as Adora gazed up at Igniatrix and clenched her fists, letting a harsh exhale through her nostrils as the hologram fades away.

Light Hope walked towards the Green crystal, oddly skipping over the golden one. Adora was dreading what the golden one contained *because she already knew who was in there* . Light Hope tapped her hand upon the Green Crystal, the melodic sound of birds and wildlife were heard as vines emerged from the holographic crystal. Then the hologram of an immensely bulky plant-like python emerged from the crystal. Though it's easily the same length as all the other God Serpents shown thus far, this one could easily outmatch them in terms of physicality.

"This is Jormun, whose domains of Earth and Life are very well

known. He is the most peaceful of the God Serpents and many Eternians worship him for his life-giving nature. Whether it is for the growth of children, crops or livestock. He is a peaceful god and a benevolent one" Light Hope explained, as the more she seemed enamored with these gods, the more Adora suspected that these gods *wanted* Light Hope to think in that way. Because if Apophis was anything to go by, these gods must be sadistic whack jobs.

Light Hope approached the golden crystal once Jormun's hologram had vanished. With every step, Light Hope seemed to get more and more excited and more…happy. The fact this was clearly programmed into her made Adora more and more nervous and afraid.

Light Hope touched the golden crystal, lightning and storm clouds emerged from it as a hellish choir grew louder and louder until a golden cobra god serpent emerged. A being that is exactly the same monster who haunts Adora's very nightmares.

"This" Light Hope said in breathless joy "is Apophis, he who commands Minds and Storms. The Great Planner and Uniter. Many of the Eternians despise him, but they know that he is the most glorious. For indeed, he is the one who is involved the most with mortals. He is the creator of the Sword, the creator…of She-Ra" Light Hope said, cocking her head over to Adora. Adora's blood ran cold as for a solid moment, Light Hope's face was warped into a terrifying ear-to-ear grin.

Chapter 5: The Empty King

Chapter 5

The Empty King

Gareth and Scorpia forced the ancient metal doors apart, revealing ancient steps that had worn away into little more but a slide. Gareth rubbed the back of his head "crap, that's a long way down" he muttered to himself before Scorpia chuckled "eh, it's not so bad boss!" she said, patting Gareth on the back, which caused the young man to lose balance and fall down the slide, his armor making sparks as it scraped the way down.

Catra, without much thinking or hesitation, dived in after her husband. Sliding down into the ancient catacombs below. The trio followed in and Entrapta, on top of Emily, ran excitedly forward, tripped, and collided with Scorpia as they both tumbled down the ancient stone slide.

They all found themselves in the heart of an ancient stone tomb. Gareth used his magic to give them some light and Entrapta had Emily also light up the way. The air was stale, but breathable. It was clear that they were the first living things to enter this place in millennia.

The ancient black stone floors were nothing like the First Ones, everyone stood around to take it all in. "I can now safely confirm that This isn't First Ones, not even early occupational era! it's...much *older* than that!! ″Entrapta said in awe before taking out one of her recorders. "Expedition log #5: We've entered an ancient catacomb. it's much older than anything I have ever seen on Etheria, not a scrap of technology to be found." she muttered softly into her recorder.

Gareth walked around and gazed upon the writing on the walls. They were, thankfully, accompanied by pictures of some kind. He kept examining it until he found a particularly...unsettling series of pictures “Hey Entrapta. Come look at this.” he said in an uncharacteristically cold voice. Entrapta approached it and had Emily’s lights fully display the series of pictures.

Everyone gathered closely to gaze upon the pictures. The carvings showed beings arriving in strange shapes, accompanied by a golden crystal, they stood before the natives. From the crystal came a large serpent, who enslaved many of the natives with the help of the beings.

The next line of these showed the spirit of a golden female humanoid being ensnared into a sword by the golden serpent. The sword was given to, what the group assumed to be, the queen of the natives who became a figure which was the spitting image for She-Ra. It seemed the natives didn’t take kindly to this, as they depicted her as a cowardly entity within these pictures.

The line afterwards shows a war between the beings and the natives, the King managed to strike the same golden serpent with a spear, causing its blood to spill onto the ground. The King gathered this blood, and a figure next to the king tried to kill him. But the king overpowered this figure and ripped its head off.

The King went into hiding and forged an unspeakable axe, made from the blood of the blue serpent and the skull of the one who tried to attack him. The King used this axe to lead his people into more war, and used his axe to kill She-Ra, who was his bride.

The fourth and final line showed the serpents smiting him and the

remains of his people along with his own were sealed into this very tomb. This story is repeated all across the walls of this room. Entrapta went wide eyed, a lot of them looked afraid, but Gareth looked rather...determined.

"So these were the natives of Etheria. The First Ones and their gods came and...killed them all." Gareth said, Entrapta looked at the crystal fused to Gareth's chest. "Gareth...Apophis...Apophis made She-Ra" she said in awe. Gareth sighed "and that axe" Gareth said tapping upon the picture of the king killing the queen. "Is a She-Ra killer. Our ticket to getting an advantage over Adora and the Rebels" he explained to which Catra nodded.

"Probably still within these ancient ruins" Catra said, she turned around to look into the darkness. "Come on." she said as she took some more steps forward. Gareth followed her and, with some hesitation, so did the others.

They went deeper into this tomb, revealing it to be more than that. Revealing it to be immense catacombs. With tunnels that extended into the darkness of this ancient mountain. Catra followed the signal that her device was displaying. Eventually they came across an ancient colosseum where the signal was coming from.

Their lights display the horrific greataxe from the mural, its head cleft into an altar of stone and its handle being held down by hundreds of cloth bands, all displaying First Ones writing. Emily shifted her lights up to show a throne, where the King's armor sat, occupied by ancient bones. Emily shifted her lights to the banners all around the arena. Showing a four horned goat skull, Catra's eyes went wide as she looked at her wedding ring. Displaying the same sigil, the ring Gareth grabbed from the Mystacor treasury

that bore the sigil, the sigil that they embedded into their wedding bands, came from this ancient civilization.

Chapter 6: Bloodbane

Chapter 6

BloodBane

Entrapta approached one of the cloth bands eager to acquire a sample. “Uhm Entrapta?” Gareth asked her “what are you doing?” he said quietly. Entrapta looked up to Gareth and smiled gently “getting a sample, I doubt one cut cloth is going to do much harm.” she said before cutting it gently. Without warning, it snapped back, causing a loud twang.

Everyone backed up and got together as each of the cloth banners suddenly started breaking one by one...then increasing. Soon causing a cacophony of snapping twangs until all of the banners fell to the dusty stone floor. The runes of the greataxe began to glow, causing the cloth bands to burn into ashes.

Gareth went over to one of the old weapon racks that littered the colosseum and grabbed himself an axe as he prepared for the worst. A red, hellish light began to glow from the armor sitting upon the throne. With the crunching of bones, the armor lurched its head up, its eyes burning with absolute hatred. It stood up from its ancient throne and extended its hand.

“ *Blooooooooodbaaaaaaaaaaaaaannneeeeeeeee* ” it hissed as the greataxe’s runes began to glow fiercely before flying into the grasp of the animate armor. It began to walk down the steps, Gareth growled and stepped forward much to Catra’s shock.

“Gareth, wait!” she said, extending her hand to him. “I’ll be fine! Just stay back!” Gareth yelled before looking up at the animated armor. “ *You challenge the Empty King?”* it snarled angrily at him, its eyes fixated upon Gareth’s crystal. “I, Gareth Elinas, do challenge you!” Gareth yelled at the Empty King.

The Empty King hissed lowly “ *If you are a trueee warrior, then you will face me with no magic. But you will never be worthy of BloodBane”* The Empty King snarled, pointing the greataxe at him, to which Gareth rolled his neck. “Bring it on Tin Can!” Gareth yelled, a determined smirk appeared on his lips.

A ring of fire surrounded both the Empty King and Gareth. The two charged at each other and collided. Despite being the same size as She-Ra, The Empty King was surprised by how much strength Gareth had as he was pushed back. Gareth slammed his axe down on the Empty King’s shoulder, spilling out ethereal light from the cracked armor.

Gareth received a brutal punch to the face for his efforts, blood dripped from his nose and his ears rang. But Gareth maintained himself, and was still in the fight. Dodging another axe swing, Gareth slammed his own axe into the Empty King’s leg causing the undead king to cry out in agony. Gareth ripped the axe out and parried a swing from his undead foe before he delivered a punch that dented the Empty King’s armor.

Gareth could hear his comrades cheering for him, he smiled a bit before parrying another oncoming blow. Gareth swung his axe into the Empty King’s chest and forced it down more, he wound up breaking the axe in two by doing this. Gareth used the broken metal shaft and stabbed the Empty King in the neck who fell down onto its knees.

The spectral and skeletal hands of the Empty King were being burnt by Bloodbane forcing him to drop it. It clattered onto the floor at Gareth's feet. Gareth picked up Bloodbane, it didn't burn him at all, he looked up at the Empty King.

" *It...chose you. Over me...I...I created it...yet it chose...you* " the Empty King said in disbelief. Gareth exhaled out of his bloodied nose as the fiery circle began to die down. "The creation outlived its creator. At least your soul will be free" Gareth said before swinging Bloodbane and taking off the Empty King's head. He watched it clatter onto the dust covered stone floor followed shortly by the body of the Empty King.

Gareth gazed upon Bloodbane and gently ran his finger over one of the runes, a smile coming across his face. He approached his comrades and smiled "well I got myself a new axe" he said to everyone's shocked faces.

Entrapta went giddy with glee "that was amazing!!!" she yelled excitedly to which Gareth nodded "yep! Say...we still have our grappling hooks right?" he asked Kyle who nodded in response. "Well then we can head back the way we came." Gareth said with a smile. "Let's head home"

Scorpia hopped up and down in place "did you SEE THAT!" Scorpia said with absolute excitement just oozing out of her voice. She couldn't believe what she saw, and while no one else would be willing to say out loud, they too were somewhat impressed.

"Ah I wasn't too worried, Boss is a freaking beast!" Kyle said with a big grin as he packed up his sniper rifle, trying to make it

discrete but Lonnie rolled her eyes “then why did you bring your sniper out?” she teased with a happy smirk.

Kyle chuckled “well Belina wanted to see the fight” Kyle suggested with a very sarcastic voice. Gareth chuckled “named your sniper eh Kyle?” he mused to which Kyle nodded. “Hey, she’s a powerful weapon! She needs a name!” Kyle said with a big cheerful grin. Gareth placed his gauntlet onto Kyle’s shoulder and smiled “hey, every good weapon needs love and respect.” Gareth said, looking at his prize with a smile. Bloodbane, a rival to the sword of protection…perfect for his glory.

Chapter 7: The Warrior And The Princess

Chapter 7

The Warrior and The Princess

The neat cobblestone roads of Mariena were bustling with activity. Mariena is one of Brightmoon's most populated cities. Just short of being a kingdom by population alone, it’s full of people from all across the free kingdoms of Etheria.

It’s even more full of activity since Brightmoon had defeated the Horde’s invasion, as refugees from other Horde-Controlled towns have been fleeing to Brightmoon for protection but also a new life.

Mariena is situated within a valley south of Brightmoon, built around two large rivers which are often filled with ships carrying valuable cargo. It’s here in which Adora headed to after the revelation Light Hope gave her, she needed to clear her mind a bit.

There really was no other place that could clear her mind as well as Mariena, the place was truly beautiful. Adora couldn’t help but smile a bit at the busy street ahead of her. A few kids were chasing each other, going past Adora as they giggled with joy.

After watching them go by, Adora began to wonder how long will this peace truly last. She made her way to the marketplace, going past a few stalls until a shining blue and silver ring caught her eyes, it resembled the shimmering of water frozen in time. Adora looked at it for a short minute, she then locked eyes with the stall owner, an elvish man, and spoke “how much for the ring?” Adora asked, mentally begging for a somewhat decent price.

“Well the ring is gonna cost you about 250 gold” he said with a casual shrug, not shifting his eyes from his current task of polishing a brass goblet. “Nabbed it from an old ruin”. Adora looked into her coin purse and she had 248 gold, placing the coins onto the stall counter. Adora sheepishly smiled at the owner as a few beads of nervous sweat appeared on her cheeks and forehead. The owner looked up from his goblet and eyed the coins, mentally counting the amount. He furrowed his brow and alternated glances between Adora and the small pile of golden coins that glittered in the sun.

He offered a small nod “sure kid” he said “i’ll take 248” he added, much to Adora’s joy. She smiled and held the ring in her hands. She took in the details of the ring, it bore the sigil of a white wolf head with a background of blue fire. It was a very neat emblem, but it wasn’t for her, it was for her beloved Glimmer who was no doubt worried about her. Adora placed the ring in her Jacket pocket who was no doubt worried about her.

Adora placed the ring in her jacket pocket and picked up Swift Wind from the stables, taking flight towards Brightmoon as soon as it was safe to take off. The trip was a quiet one, Adora’s mind was still troubled by the knowledge that she was granted, she could easily discern the propaganda that spewed from Light Hope’s mouth. The Eternians were mere Slaves to the God Serpents not to mention the fact that the worst of them was in fact fused to her brother’s chest was nothing short of staggering, especially as it was the same one haunting her nightmares.

Adora sighed as she rubbed the side of Swift Wind’s neck, the cool wind past her, causing her Adora’s hair to flow and flutter like a

flag. Flying always brought her a gentle relief from the troubles that plagued her on the ground. Moments like this make her wonder what it would be like to have wings of her own, she turned her gaze to the setting sun as the moons began to rise over the horizon. The familiar black featureless night sky was soon visible. She smiled, a bit tiredly, as they drew closer and closer to home.

Brightmoon, where everything was going to be alright. This brief ceasefire won't last, soon the Horde will be ready to fight and continue the combat that she was so familiar with. But something was making her nervous, she could feel it in her bones. Despite her mentally telling herself that she was ready, all she could feel is Fear.

Eventually Adora landed on the courtyard with Swift Wind, holding the ring in between her fingers, it gave her calmness, joy but also a bit of nervousness. Adora pocketed the ring, she knew now wasn't exactly the time nor the place for such a momentous proposal…she'd have to wait. She only hoped that she didn't have to wait too long.

Adora sighed as Swift Wind flew off to the stables and she herself yawned as she walked over to her room, opened the door and sat in bed. She hesitated however as her hand touched the pillow, would she have nightmares again?

Her brows furrowed in frustration "why can't you leave me alone" Adora muttered to the air around her as she placed the ring into a safe and hidden spot of her room. She looked at her sword in the pale moonlight and began to wonder *who* was the one who chose

her? Was it the sword? Was it the true She-Ra? Was it Apophis? Who was the only who decided to give her this burden of savior?

Adora gazed upon a strange smudge on the sword and she gently touched it only for the smudge to move, grow and warp until it was the outline of a grinning Cobra. Adora's blood ran colder than the ice of Frosta's kingdom.

Adora blinked and looked away for a few seconds before looking at the sword again, seeing that nothing was there, she let out a soft sigh and laid back on her bed, letting the sword gently rest on the floor. She didn't notice the storm clouds surrounding brightmoon, and how eerily the golden Lightning was…

Chapter 8: Prisoner

Chapter 8

Prisoner

Gareth walked down the dimly lit halls of the Fright Zone's prison. He could tell that it was getting late as the pale green lights began to flicker off one by one. He carried a large tray with prisoner grade ration bars, Gareth volunteered for this job due to his own desire to get answers, his metal books clanked against the metal floors. He felt the knife of anxiety twist into his heart as he continued to walk.

As he drew closer to the cell that held Shadow Weaver, his steps slowed to a crawl. He mentally shook off Apophis' whispers into his mind, they were getting exponentially more and more hostile...and that spooked him quite a bit. Thankfully, Gareth could see in the dim light of the cell that Shadow Weaver was crouched in the center of the cell but he couldn't tell if she was meditating or if that was something else entirely.

He let out a long exhale from his nose before unlocking the cell door. "Hey Mom, I mean I…" Gareth stammered before cursing under his breath and then recollecting his thoughts. "Dinner's Ready" He said, setting down the tray full of what could be debated as food. Gareth closed the door behind him and sat down, his back pressed against the wall.

Shadow Weaver looked at him and then the tray of food. There was a brief moment of silence before Gareth decided to speak "I

read your files on us" Gareth said, these words sparked a brief period of shock in her. "You knew about She-Ra this whole time and you were using me and Catra as...pawns to control her. Then there's that whole mess with my actual mother." He mused with a hint of anger and sadness in his voice.

Shadow Weaver felt her heart ache a bit "That...was the original purpose. But as the years went by I had forgotten it." Shadow Weaver explained gently. "Then why were you so cruel to us!?" Gareth suddenly snapped at her, clearly he was suppressing a large amount of emotions and they had now been suddeny unleashed.

Shadow Weaver remained calm "Hordak demands absolute order and submission. You and Catra were constantly defying him and many others, you still are. Back then, Hordak wanted to kill you both. He had killed cadets...mere children...before and he would have done so to you two. What I did was an attempt to keep you both somewhat safe. I took no pleasure or joy in doing what I did." She explained before getting up and then sitting next to Gareth, rubbing his knuckles.

Gareth sighed softly as he rested the back of his head on the wall. Weaver noted this and looked down. "You weren't an easy child to raise either, compared to your sisters. Loud noises bother you and…well you barely spoke. I recall that you needed that little spinner thing just to focus. But you developed thanks to your sisters and that trio." Shadow Weaver mused. Gareth gently touched his chest "I...didn't find out why you...did this" he said softly.

Shadow Weaver sighed “you fell ill, and i found out that well...you had magic in you. Humans, as I have come to realize, aren’t supposed to use magic. It was toxic to you. Clearly your father, whatever he was, was a magical being. The crystal, called the Storm’s Shard, was meant to stabilize you. It did work, clearly, but...i didn’t suspect that it was inhabited by another being,” she said, looking into her surrogate son’s green eyes.

Gareth was silent for a few moments but then nodded “well...thanks for that.” He said, he then looked down “Catra...wasn’t happy. She wanted to...you know…” Gareth’s voice trailed off, Shadow Weaver already knew the answer. “Yes, I do know and no doubt you wanted to do the same...or at least thought of it” Shadow Weaver suggested, Gareth nodded without breaking his gaze on the floor.

“Can you blame us? Especially with Adora?” Gareth asked, mentally flinching from Apophis’ venomous whispers. He sighed and rubbed the bridge of his nose, “do you remember why Hordak tortures me for every failure?” Gareth asked, looking her in the eyes.

Shadow Weaver nodded “someone planted a dagger under your pillow, Hordak was convinced that you were out to kill him, that was when you were a teen. Why do you ask?” She asked, Gareth stood up and walked towards the door. “I wanted to see if you didn’t believe that I actually owned that dagger. Hordak’s sending you to Beast Island, I wanted to say goodbye...thank you for everything mom” Gareth said, feeling a part of him was at peace. He then closed the cell door behind him.

Shadow Weaver felt her face grow with tears, they dripped under her mask. She slowly removed her mask and dried her eyes, she walked back to the center of the room and shifted one of the older trays, which Gareth had forgotten to collect. An elaborate rune was revealed to be under this old tray, it hummed gently. Shadow Weaver hovered her hand over it "goodbye my children." she muttered before pressing the rune and vanishing in a flash of light, this would result in dire consequences for Gareth, who Hordak believed to have let Shadow Weaver escape.

In the barracks, mere hours later, Catra was beyond angry, her claws rip into a locker. "It's that bitch's fault! Not his!" She yelled as Scorpia tried to calm her down. "Easy, easy. He'll take it, he's strong like that" Scorpia gently replied, trying to be comforting. Entrapta lifted an eyebrow as she walked in "Wait, isn't Gareth just going to get yelled at? I get that it sucks but...this seems much" she asked.

Lonnie was the first to respond "Gareth gets brutally tortured for every failure he is responsible for" Lonnie explained grimly. Entraptra gasped in horror, she bolted out of the barracks. Her heart was pounding against her chest as she ran. Entrapta couldn't believe that this was happening the entire time. She needed this to end, she refused to let him suffer for this.

Entrapta rushed by several Horde Soldiers, nearly tripping as she did so. "Sorry! Trying to save my friend from pain!" She called out in her trademark fast speech, she placed a few fingers in her mouth and whistled. She smiled as Emily soon joined her side, Entrapta rode her robot towards Hordak, narrowly colliding with groups of Horde personnel. She and Emily arrived just in time "Stop! Hordak! Stop!" Entrapta yelled which caused the entire throne room to grow silent.

They all looked at the two, Gareth smiled upon seeing them. “Hey Entrapta! Hey Emily!” He called out to them, and Entrapta waved gently with one of her hair arms in response. She then focused on Hordak “Hordak! You can’t do this! Gareth has done so much for everyone!” Entrapta yelled, a ember of anger grew in her heart.

Hordak scoffed and waved his hand in dismissal “and? Your point?”, Entrapta clenched her fists and sighed letting them go. “If you keep doing this…” she said “then I quit” she added, looking Hordak in the eyes. There was a brief tension in the air before Hordak nodded to his guards to free Gareth.

Gareth looked at Entrapta with a smile “thanks” he said, to which Entrapta couldn’t help but smile right back. Entrapta gave him a pat on the shoulder “hey no problem at all!” Entrapta said with a cheery grin. Entrapta walked back and got back onto Emily, making her way back to the Barracks.

Entrapta hummed as she gazed on her device, logging away various data entries before Emily stopped. Entrapta snapped out of her busy work to see Catra standing before her “oh hey Catra!” Entrapta said as she got off Emily and walked towards her, but before she could say another word Catra gave her a vice-grip like hug, letting out a soft purr.

“Th…thank you” Catra said softly, on the verge of losing her composure and crying. Entrapta smiled and patted her back. “Any time Catra, any time”

Chapter 9: Embers Anew

Chapter 9

Embers Anew

Back at the barracks an hour after Entrapta stood up for Gareth. Entrapta had arranged for a private meeting with Gareth, but it was more akin to a briefing than anything else.

"Well, now that we got that nasty business out of the way" Entrapta explained as Gareth habitually rubbed his wrists, which were still sore from the bindings "i'm working on a special project, Gareth." She excitedly added "but to complete this project, we're gonna do an expedition into the crimson wastes!"

Gareth's eyes went as wide as baseballs "isn't that place completely lifeless??" He exclaimed but Entrapta shook her head. "Nope! Besides, there's a major piece of First Ones tech there!" She excitedly said.

In Brightmoon, the rebels gathered in the war room as Queen Angella looked in concern at the war room table which displayed the vast desert known as the crimson wastes. Within a valley region, there was a signal emanating from the deepest part of the region. No doubt of it being of First One origin. Angella began as soon as Adora, Glimmer and the rest of the princess alliance sat down. "There is a strong signal coming from the southeastern part of the Crimson Wasted, no doubt that the Horde will be after

it as well. I cannot stress enough how dangerous it is in that godsforsaken land" Angella explained.

Glimmer awkwardly drummed her fingers on the war table "Maaaybe you can send us to go and check it out?" She asked with a shy grin. Angella shot her a volcanic glare which made the princess of Brightmoon sink into her seat a bit more. "Glimmer! There's deadly monsters, warlords with armies of barbarians and not to mention the fact that the heat could cook a cow!" Angella yelled in a fit of motherly concern. Adora sighed and rubbed the bridge of her nose, as much as she loved them as family, Glimmer and Angella needed to air out their issues. "But Mom! Me, Bow and Adora are best suited for this! Besides, Hordak's gonna send his A-Team after this First One tech once he's good and ready!" Glimmer exasperated which got Bow pondering about something.

Adora sighed and looked at the war map until she saw something curious on it. Hostiled were detected at one of the small villages that boarded brightmoon. "Guys!" She yelled before pointing at the war map which caused panic to surge through the war room. Adora wasted no time to head to the threat, riding on Swift Wind. The village was engulfed in flames as horde robots were ravaging the village, its inhabitants fleeing for their lives.

Adora growled and had Swift Wind land, "Swifty! Get these people to safety!" She yelled to which Swift wind nodded "right! On it!" He said and got right to it. Adora went into She-Ra mode and saw Glimmer and Bow warp in. Glimmer had only a moment to take in the destruction and death before Adora had to block laser fire aimed at Glimmer's head.

“Babe! Focus!” Adora shouted as Bow fired an emp arrow into the eye of one of these immense mechanisms. It stumbled back into a house which collapsed like a house of cards. Adora swung her sword with the force of a comet and cleaved the other Horde bot in half, her grin was short lived as the cleaved robot managed to duplicate. Creating two from the halves. “Oooh shiiit…” Adora muttered as the robots opened fire, Adora just managed to turn her sword into a shield just in time but the force of the blast launched her through several buildings.

Glimmer used her magic to try and stop the robot from firing but only managed to redirect the cannons into a small stable. Adora got up and readied to block another blast when the ground erupted and massive vines crushed the robots. The rebel trio turned to look at Perfuma who was slightly hurt, Bow rushed over to her. “Perfuma?” He asked “are you okay??”, Perfuma nodded, her dress was stained with dirt “a couple of those robots showed up at Aromia, I couldn’t save them all.” Perfuma muttered, Bow comforted her as Adora gazed up at the robots, they were still very interested in killing them but were immobilized by Perfuma’s vines. Adora squinted as she saw something shimmering inside a large crack in one of the robots.

Adora climbed up one of the vines and ripped out the shimmering object which caused the robot to immediately power down. Glimmer could see Adora’s face which displayed terror. “Adora?” Glimmer asked “what did you find?” Adora climbed and showed them the object, a blend of Horde and First Ones technology. “That...that looks like Entrapta’s work” Bow muttered in horror to which Perfuma covered her face in abject shock.

“We left her to die…” Adora muttered but Glimmer shook her head “but she’s alive! And clearly she’s being forced to work for

Hordak!” She yelled out “we need to find out where they’re keeping her!” She declared with a determined voice. Bow and Perfuma nodded, Adora sighed and then looked at them “We need either Catra or Gareth” Adora explained

“Well they can’t be too far.” Bow pondered, luckily they weren’t too far off. Outside the border of the whispering wood,the rebels came across a patrol being led by Gareth. Adora lunged onto the road and cut down a few soldiers, in response to this, Adora got an intimate introduction to Gareth’s new greataxe which hit like a comet. Luckily her wound healed due to being in her She-Ra form and she was able to block Gareth’s next attack.

“Hello Adora, been waiting to try this axe out! Its name is Bloodbane.” Gareth said with a snarl, he then continued to unleash a flurry of attacks which Adora was unprepared to fully withstand this assault and was knocked flat on her butt and Gareth raised Bloodbane over his head and was ready to cleave into her.

Adora dodged out of the way as the ground was split by Gareth’s axe blow, Adora was shocked by this power and blocked Gareth’s wild strikes with her sword. But blow after blow was getting Adora knocked back further and further, it came to a point where Adora was practically kneeling with the sword being her only shield from Gareth’s barbaric fury.

“Hey!” Glimmer yelled, getting Gareth’s green eyed gaze and attention. Glimmer had picked up a Horde pistol and was holding Catra hostage. “Come with us and your cat wife gets to live” the princess of Brightmoon snarled. Gareth looked at them, saw Catra’s scared eyes before he placed his axe on the ground, Catra

carefully picked up his axe, “I’ll get help…” Catra assured Gareth, glaring at the others and running off. Adofa watched as Perfuma wrapped vines around him. Gareth looked at his captors with hatred and defiance.

Chapter 10: Questions

Chapter 10

Questions

Adora sat in front of Gareth who hadn't spoken since they caught him. They had been taking the long route to Brightmoon, which was more hidden than the usual shorter route. The Rebels have been hoping to avoid detection from any Horde pursuers. "Come on Gareth, we just want answers" Adora said, leaning against the tree they had him tied to, Gareth looked at her for a few seconds before looking away,

In sheer frustration, Adora punched the tree which left a sizable dent "Talk!!!" She yelled angrily, snarling like some feral beast. Gareth remained silent for a moment before talking "just torture me already" he muttered angrily. Perfuma walked over to Gareth and nodded towards Adora, who walked away, Perfuma sat in front of Gareth and he could see that she had a tray of food and a ceramic cup of water.

"We do not perform torture Gareth. We're better than that, I can tell you have many...issues. Please, feel free to talk about them." Perfuma discussed calmly and with a smile, she had a a small berry and popped it into her mouth. Gareth exhaled through his nose "Well for starters, I have no loyalty to Hordak or his damn horde." Gareth said with a low snarl, his voice was a bit dry.

Perfuma smiled and placed the cup against his lips, allowing Gareth to drink from the lip of the cup. "Then why serve him?"

Perfuma said softly “well, I have loyalty to my friends, to my love...thaaaat and I plan to overthrow the Horde.” He admitted with a small grin and a fire in his eyes that seemed to outshine the campfire itself.

“I want to make a kingdom where Strength, Loyalty and Freedom are its core values. I will build that from the bones of the Horde” Gareth explained, which Perfuma took note “care to explain?”, she wanted to understand Gareth and hopefully by understanding his ideas he would be more willing to answer questions. “Strength, where you are rewarded for your greatest trait. For example...your strength would be tolerance. Loyalty, for those who you fight beside and to defend home and family. Freedom, so that you can pursue whatever you please and choose your path in life” Gareth explained calmly.

Perfuma then sighed a bit, remembering the battle of Plumera. “Do...do you regret killing those people during the battle?” She asked. Gareth looked at her “it’s war...That’s the ugly truth. There are enemies in war, and...well I’m not sure if mercy’s on the table in the case of war” He explained “and before you mention honor...stand in the graves of a thousand dead souls and ask the damn ghosts if honor truly matters”

Perfuma tensed up and exhaled “is Entrapta with you, or with Hordak?” She asked. Gareth smiled a bit “she is alive and well, while she is working for Hordak on some project, her loyalty lies with me. He continued, his grin growing ever more. Perfuma and the others looked on in disbelief before Adora yelled angrily “you’re lying!”, Gareth chuckled as his team emerged from the bushes.

Scorpia had a frown on her face “Boss is many things but not a Liar!” She yelled as Catra leaped over Scorpia and dive kicked Glimmer to the ground. Catra went over and freed Gareth “are you okay honey?” She asked to which he nodded. Lonnie pulled out a tablet, she and Gareth exchanged a glance. After Gareth waved his hand, Lonnie flicked it on and Entrapta appeared on the Tablet screen.

“Entrapta!?” Bow exclaimed in surprise. “Hello...Rebels” Entrapta said in a grim tone of voice that was unlike her “you abandoned me” Entrapta added bitterly, her face was covered by her mask. “Left me to die...but Gareth helped me”. Bow struggled to respond but Glimmer spoke up “we thought you were dead!” She shouted but Entrapta was unmoved.

“Let me tell you a secret. Me and Hordak are building a portal, the Horde is just a simple offshoot of a Galactic Horde. Hordak will summon Horde Prime and he will annihilate you all” Entrapta said in a icy tone of voice, Adora could tell that even Gareth’s team was shocked by this revelation.

“I believe that the key to completing the Portal is in the crimson wastes. I suggest you try and beat us to it” Entrapta lowly snarled before she cut the transmission. Glimmer was about to attack but Adora stopped her “let them go, we need to get ready.” Adora said looking at Gareth and Catra who simply walked off with their friends leaving the rebels behind.

It took a solid month of preparation for both sides before the teams were deployed. Gareth felt the sand shift under his boots. The heat was intense but welcoming, at least to him and Scorpia. Catra muttered as her hair felt like it was cooking her. “Damn can’t

we take a break!?” Catra yelled as Gareth wiped some sweat from his brow, his wife was right.

They needed a place to at least rest, Lonnie was the first one to see it, a large tavern was in the distance. The tavern was seemingly constructed from various chunks of scrap metal. Gareth and his team entered the tavern, they were immediately beset by angry glares from the tavern patrons.

A Satyr and Frogkin were sitting at the bar enjoying some drinks. Catra went to the bar, this prompted the frogkin to croak angrily. Catra responded in kind with a vicious feline hiss which caused the frogkin to immediately back off. Gareth smirked and nudged Scorpia with his elbow “see that Scorps? Around here you gotta be tough!” He said with a cocky grin.

Kyle sat at a table to look at the scanner to properly examine the results. Gareth sat next to his wife and look at the bartender “say pal, we’re looking for a cache of First One Tech, any ideas?” He asked with a smile. The Barkeeper scoffed “A group of ol’ buggas asked for da same fing. Sum blondie and ‘er friends.” The Barkeep explained. Gareth slammed his fist on the bar “damnit!!” He growled, before he could say much more Kyle made a yelp.

Catra looked to the sound only to see Kyle being held at knife point by a thug in a snake themed leather jacket “you fucks are gonna come -“ the punk’s words were cut short by Gareth’s greataxe flying through the air and cleaving him vertically in half. Bloodbane’s runes glowed as it drained the blood from the corpse. Gareth walked over and ripped Bloodbane from the corpse “anyone else?” Gareth growled as the patrons looked on in shock and awe.

“No? Good then.” Gareth said as Lonnie helped Kyle. Scorpia and Gareth chuckled, Catra walked over to her husband. “Sooo, hun, shall we pursue Adora and her friends?” She said with a smile to which Gareth nodded. “Ooh-fuckin-rah” he said, taking Catra’s hand before they walked outside to see a huge group of marauders, without thinking both Gareth and Scorpia pushed Catra and the trio back inside, putting themselves between the marauders and the tavern.

Gareth pulled out his shotgun and fired all 3 barrels at once, the 6 gauge shells reduced a large group of the marauders into bloody chunks. Then he sheathed his shotgun and cleaved into the other marauders with Bloodbane, scorpia joined in the brawl. Unfortunately the Marauders had some kind of tranquilizing poison on their weapons, the two eventually passed out.

Gareth felt the darkness take him as his eyes closed.

Chapter 11: Revna

Chapter 11

Revna

Gareth could hear Apophis' vile whispers in his mind as he drifted in the dark void. Gareth could see memories that were not his own. He could see worlds drowned in boiling rain, he witnessed vast storms rip apart entire cities. The innocents screaming in agony as a vast golden serpent raised his claws and laughed in pure unrivalled glee.

Gareth wanted to scream, he wanted to stop it but he felt like his body was not his own. He felt like he was drowning in his own mind as a vile force took his body for his own. Then he woke up with a jolt.

Gareth stared at the stone ceiling, trying to collect his thoughts. After a minute, he slowly sat up. Gareth felt pain grow in his ribs, he laid back down and saw Scorpia next to him. She was cuffed and Gareth could see that they were in a large room that was decorated with runes and symbols that were unlike anything he had ever seen but yet they were familiar to him...somehow.

"Boss?" Scorpia said quietly, keeping her voice down. "Scorps? Where...are we?" Gareth muttered. Scorpia tried shifting around to get a good look at her surroundings "I have no idea." She admitted. Then the door to the room opened wide and a green armored knight walked in, Gareth sat up despite the pain "who

are you!?” He yelled, the crystal in his chest glowing wildly through the bandages around his chest.

The knight reached with a clawed gauntlet and stroked his cheek, Scorpia blinked in surprise. “I have spent years searching for you” the knight softly said, she then removed her antlered helmet.

Both Gareth and Scorpia had eyes the size of dinner plates. The woman looked so much like Gareth. “My son, I have missed you so much” she said softly, her green eyes met Gareth’s own green eyes.

“My name is Revna Elinas, Gareth...do you still have that name or has that Witch taken that from you?” She asked, Gareth managed to answer even though he has a bunch of confused feelings. “Yes, I still have that name” he said.

Revna offered a gentle nod, she stood up and freed Scorpia from her bonds, “I owe you both an apology for the way my subordinates have treated you.” She said as she then freed Gareth from his own bonds, “I am one of the warlords under Lashor’s command, been that for years” Revna explained as Gareth listened.

After a few more moments, Gareth asked the most pressing question on his mind. “What about my friends and my wife Catra? Are they okay?” This question prompted a small smile on the otherwise expressionless face of Revna. “It seems Odin continues to bless me, you are married to a strong warrior. She has carved a bloody path and is gaining a large army.” Revna said softly.

Gareth and Scorpia exchanged glances before looking at Revna. "Odin?" Gareth asked to which Revna sighed. "You don't know about our people. I should have guessed." She muttered. Gareth furrowed his brow a bit more "wait wait...I thought you were dead!?" He exclaimed, recalling what Shadow Weaver's file said about him.

"A slaver found me and healed my wounds, I wound up killing him before he could sell me into that abhorrent practice. In the wastes, I gathered a sizable force before Lashor decided to take me in." Revna explained. Scorpia didn't say anything, she merely observed this reunion of son and mother.

Revna hugged Gareth for a brief moment before she continued "we are a part of a civilization of humans known as Vikings. I will tell you everything about our people. I used my connections to learn that you and the rebels were after First Ones technology. Your mission is going be delayed, even if you went free, the rebels were ambushed and you need a sizable force to get through that part of the wastes." Revna added.

Gareth sighed and agreed to this with a nod. "Fine, but treat Scorpia with respect. I'm not gonna comply unless my friend is treated right" he requested, to which Revna complied. "Of course" she responded with a gentle tone of voice. She then turned to leave "i must tend to my duties but I will be back later" she said before placing on her helmet and walking out.

After an odd silence, Scorpia looked at Gareth "Boss?" She asked, Gareth sighed. "Yeah I know...but I can't pass up the opportunity

to learn about my people. Besides, even if she's clearly my birth mother, it's clear she has her own motives. I refuse to be another pawn." Gareth explained, Scorpia smiled seeing that he wasn't going to be so easily manipulated, "glad to hear it Boss" Scorpia said.

In the coming days, Revna would continue to educate Gareth in everything about Vikings. Everything from their culture to even what they love to eat. Gareth took in all of this and some of this information even resonated with him, especially the love of axes. They were treated fairly by the people under Revna's command, but they had hoped that they would eventually get to leave. While Gareth was learning about his people's culture, Scorpia found a passion in cooking, finding it to be fun to do.

Revna even taught her how to make mead and other viking recipes. While this was happening both him and Scorpia always kept track of where they were and hints as to what was going on. They found out that they were in this massive fortress city ruled by a tyrant named Lashor who had warlords under his command each with their own armies.

Revna was one of these warlords, she had converted most of the population under her rule into vikings with Gareth now being established to inherit this rule and Revna may or may not be planning a revolution in order to take over.

Yet, despite all that he has learned, Revna has not talked a word about his father which frustrated him to no end. All he got was that Skeletor was the name of his father, but nothing else outside of that. One night, Gareth sat at his desk as he read one of his

mother’s books. It was a cool evening as the wind flowed through the window as the candle light flickered.

Gareth heard the door to the room open and close, Gareth turned his head towards the visitor he had. Revna stood in a green dress bordered by black runes. “You wished to see me my son?” Revna asked. Gareth closed the book and looked Revna straight in the eye “Who is my father ? All i know is that his name is Skeletor” Gareth replied, his voice was cold as ice.

Revna locked the door behind her and sat in front of him “your father is a powerful sorceror and warrior, a being of immense power and relentless ambition. His mastery of dark and forbidden magic is unmatched...he once served a being known as Horde Prime but ultimately rebelled against him” Revna explained “I love him, just as much as I love you. Perhaps one day we will be able to be a family once more”

Gareth processed this information, he was the child of two beings not of this world, part of a species that knew violence as much as it knew compassion. It was dizzying as it said much about himself, he cared about his wife and friends like family and yet he could slaughter his enemies with savage brutality.

At that moment, both Revna and Gareth heard war horns echo in the darkness. Gareth looked out the window and saw a massive army at the gates. It was Catra and the Trio! Gareth smiled, he knew that not only Lashor’s days were numbered but so was Hordak’s. Everything was falling into place.

Chapter 12: Blood On The Risers

Chapter 12

Blood on the Risers

Catra gazed upon the fortress made by Lashor. Her uniform was decorated with the trophies of the other tyrants, their teeth and bones decorated her lightly worn outfit and her crown was decorated by two horns that gave her a devilish appearance.

"I can see weak points we can exploit" Lonnie said standing next to Catra. Rogelio let out a growl and Kyle smiled "ready for battle!" He shouted as he cocked his sniper rifle. Catra stood straight and pulled out a sword, pressed a button on the handle and it became a bladed whip "RIP AND TEAR!!!" Catra yelled at the top of her lungs as her army charged.

Their bullet based weapons were not as powerful as the laser weapons of the Horde but they sure were satisfying as they ripped apart the defenders. They smashed through the front gate as Kyle sniped several other snipers. Catra showed no mercy as she reduced her enemies into clouds of gore with her snake sword. She saw groups of runed warriors joining her side.

Catra didn't complain about this in the slightest! She smirked as she then dodged a large claymore swing and caught it with her whip. With a violent tug, her snake sword shattered the claymore and she slashed her foe's throat with her claws. Getting the now familiar warm splash of crimson onto her body, catra grinned and kept on the warpath "Keep at it!" Catra yelled as she sped along,

her feet pressed against the warm adobe stone, stained with blood.

Catra kicked down a door expecting a group of enemies but was surprised to see Scorpia doing some cooking. “Scorpia?” Catra asked, tilting her head but Scorpia smiled excitedly “Wildcat!” She said happily before putting down the tray of biscuits she had been cooking. “I’m glad to see you!” Scorpia added as Catra stood there in confusion.

Catra then shook her head rapidly as if the action would dispel her confusion “Where’s Gareth? And what’s with the runed people fighting with us?” Catra asked, she was confused as to what they were doing. Scorpia tapped her claws together “well one of the warlords happens to be a human, like Gareth! She claims to be his actual mom and has been teaching him about vikings.” Scorpia said.

Catra stood there, jaw agape, raising her hand and firing her revolver which blasted a hostile warrior’s head off. All without breaking eye contact with Scorpia. “The lady vanished shortly after you showed up but she had Gareth take over her forces.” Scorpia finished her conversation.

Catra closed her mouth and nodded gently “well grab a weapon! I’m gonna go kill Lashor!” Catra said as she holstered her revolver and unsheathed her sword. She ran through the chaotic streets, seeing several of Lashor’s warriors getting cleaved and their limbs were sent flying like bloody fireworks, Gareth’s horde armor was covered by blood and Bloodbane was drenched in blood as well.

Him and Catra locked eyes, the two married warriors smiled before running into each other's arms. "Hey kit kat" Gareth said gently and Catra purred a bit before "I missed you hun" she replied gently, the two let go of each other before gazing onto the northern road whose crimson stained adobe pavings was filled with Lashor's marauders, charging down the road towards them.

Gareth casually flicked the blood off his gauntlets before stomping the spiked pommel of Bloodbane into the stones, a bunch of the viking warriors that served Revna went to Gareth's side. "Warriors! Rip and Tear!!!" Gareth yelled and pointed Bloodbane at Lashor's marauders. The warriors showed little mercy as they attacked with Gareth and Catra entering the fray.

They slaughtered their way towards the palace of Lashor which was at the top of this mountainous fortress. Catra gazed at the big stone gates as Gareth pushed open the doors. The two began to walk down the halls and towards the throne room, Gareth flipped out his shotgun and blasted groups of marauders into gore filled chunks. Gareth couldn't get enough of the thunderous firepower it provided,

Catra unloaded her revolver, the incendiary ammo ignited several unfortunate guards who cried out in agony as they burned to death. Catra and Gareth arrived at the main door that led to the throne room, they took the time to clean the blood off of themselves and reload their guns. Once they were ready, they kicked the door open and saw the large purple snake man known as Lashor sit upon his throne, "so, you bastards want my armies?? My city!? Come and die to Tongue Lashor!!" He yelled and stood.

The tyrant then stood shocked as Gareth and Catra laughed at him. “That is fucking hilarious!” He said wiping a tear from his eye “but I'm in a rush sooo….” Gareth said before flipping out his shotgun, but Lashor whipped it out of his hand with his whip and shoulder rammed him into the wall.

Gareth dug his hands into Lashor’s neck and unleashed a barrage of golden lightning into him as Catra slashed Lashor’s back with her sword. Carving large bloody gashes into the snake man. Lashor was forced back as Gareth readied bloodbane and cleaved into the tyrant’s shoulder but Lashor punched Gareth extremely hard into the wall and yanked the axe out of his shoulder.

Gareth and Lashor locked hands, Catra wrapped her snake sword around lashor’s neck. The individual blades sliced into Lashor’s neck as Catra dug into his back. Lashor wildly swung about as Catra pulled more and more, allowing the blades to dig deeper and deeper. With a defiant roar, Catra jumped up and caused the sword to tear off Lashor’s head, his face frozen in shock as it hit the floor.

Gareth smiled and approached Catra. The two have claimed this fortress and its armies, now it was time to pursue their goal.

Chapter 13: The Ship

Chapter 13

The Ship

After a month and a half of travel, trying to chase after thieves who robbed them and finally trying to survive, Adora and her friends finally found the First Ones tech...it was Mara's ship.

This legendary cache of tech could forever change the war. Adora gazed at the large pale purple woman who led them here. "Well here you guys are, sorry about the ambushing thing" the woman, known as Huntara, said. Glimmer smiled and patted her back "hey as long as you don't do it again, besides we're here now" Glimmer replied before they all went down and into the crater.

Adora had to pry open the door with her she-ra strength before the group could enter. The interior was old, ancient and dark akin to a tomb. "Well this is grim. Stay close and watch out for traps" Adora said and carefully stepped around the decrepit ship, they soon entered the cockpit where behind the captain's chair was a large crystal chain to the ceiling. A sizable chunk of it was missing.

Glimmer and Bow looked at it in horror but Adora and Huntara were left confused. "The Storm's Eye" Glimmer said in terrified awe, she then looked at Adora and Huntara "this was Apophis' Crystal!" She yelled which brought Adora into a wide eyed shock. "What the hell is it doing here!?!" She exclaimed and backed up, causing her elbow to bash into the chair causing Adora to cry out in pain,

The ship began to hum to life, Bow cried out in fear and Huntara reached for her spear. Adora saw a hologram begin to flicker to life. It showed a beautiful woman who was using the sword of protection as a crutch, her body was covered in wounds and blood. Even in her she-ra form, the wounds wouldn't heal.

"My name is Mara...I send this message to my successor, I am sealing Etheria into the void. Do not believe the lies of the gods, The First Ones...the Eternians are their slaves. I had to kill...or try to kill Apophis for his attempt to restore his physical body. But now I...feel him inside my mind. Oppress, I'm so sorry, give my love to Zed. Successor...never let the barrier be broken." In that moment Mara violently twitched as her eyes glowed golden, she raised her blade. The hologram faded the moment the blade dug into her chest.

Adora backed up as the grim realization set upon her mind. The sword is the key to the portal all this time, she made her way outside and her thoughts were interrupted when she gazed upon an army that was standing outside. Gareth and Catra grinned at her "hey Adora" Catra said with a grin. Adora reached for her sword but the warriors cocked their guns, Gareth simply grinned as the warriors went inside the ship, there was the sound of a scuffle but ultimately the rebels were caught.

Glimmer, Bow, Adora and Huntara were brought onto their knees. Catra sat on the captain's chair gazing upon the sword of protection. Gareth walked in "So, Lonnie and the rest of the trio are gonna manage our forces here in the wastes until we can start our revolution in the Fright zone" he explained while looking at Catra.

Catra sighed “I saw that hologram, the sword is the key to the portal…” Catra explained “if Hordak contacts Prime…all of this would have gone to waste” Catra sadly mused. Gareth looked at her “he won’t” he said before leaving the room.

Once outside of the room Gareth clutched his head “let me have your body! Let me in!!!” Apophis hissed in his mind, Gareth punched the nearby wall before mentally forcing Apophis back. He’s gotten more and more bolder, now on the brink of outright possessing him.

Gareth, Catra, Scorpia and their prisoners went into the fright zone where they were welcomed happily. Gareth and Catra retired into their room as well as everyone else. Getting some well earned rest, when morning finally came Entrapta summoned the squad to reveal the disturbing news.

“So if we open the portal, we could ruin reality” Entrapta said grimly, Gareth sighed “well then we can’t do it” he said, he went to get his axe. “No!! We don’t need to revolt, I can tell Hordak! He’ll listen!” Entrapta yelled. Gareth clutched his axe for a few more seconds but he let go.

Entrapta ran off without a second thought. Catra was worried about Entrapta and Scorpia looked like she was going to cry. Entrapta entered the room in which the portal was being constructed. “Hordak!” She yelled, Adora was chained to a pillar but this didn’t phase the avid scientist.

Hordak looked at Entrapta with a cold indifference “yes?” He said. Entrapta looked him in the eyes “don’t do it! If we open this portal, then we will all die!” Entrapta explained “Etheria is in some sort of dimensional quarantine. If we break it then we could all die.” Entrapta pleaded to Hordak but all she got was an icy cold stare.

“Prime is everything, and now you wish to disrupt this!?” Hordak roared which caused Entrapta to back up and tremble in fear. Before Entrapta could respond, Hordak’s guards entered the room, “Take her to Beast Island!” Hordak roared to the guards who grabbed her, and Entrapta began to cry “please! This isn’t you!” She cried out, tears rolled down her cheeks but Hordak ignored her, Adora could only watch Entrapta get dragged away.

Gareth collapsed onto his knees outside the throne room, he tried to stop Hordak but Apophis was cackling into his mind louder than a jet engine. “Entrapta failed! Now your only hope to prevent Horde Prime is to surrender to me!” Apophis laughed cruelly. “You were my puppet! I never truly cared for you, and now...now surrender to me or everything you love will die as your precious dream turns into dust!!”

Hordak began to power up the portal after typing up a message to Horde Prime. Adora struggled more but then noticed the console that was meant for Prime’s message was hacked remotely and the message was deleted. Adora then gazed upon the portal coming to life, sucking in random debris.

Hordak stood before the portal, a cruel grin dancing across his lips. Adora then saw Gareth enter the room, there was something

wrong. Like she was seeing something that was wearing his skin rather than Gareth himself. His eyes were golden and glowing.

Hordak turned to look at Gareth but then his eyes began to glow gold. “Let me activate the portal” Gareth commanded in a voice that was not his own. Hordak stepped aside, his eyes glowing. Adora realized that this was Apophis possessing Gareth and she couldn’t do anything as this ancient god used her brother like a puppet.

Apophis had his puppet grab the lever, grin at Adora, and then pull it. Adora blacked out as her vision was filled with immense light and the sound of evil godly laughter rang around her ears.

Chapter 14: Worlds of Torment

Chapter 14

Worlds of Torment

Everything is perfect are the three words that went through the twisted mind of Apophis as he looked over a dead and shattered Etheria whose rings were once its many moons. Apophis hissed with delight as he gazed upon the small realms he had devised to eternally torment the mortals of Etheria, including his former host.

Each realm floated around his electrified golden scales, he can easily hold them in his claws like how a mortal would hold an egg. Each of these realms are focused upon their greatest flaw, made into their own personal hell. Apophis gazed upon Entrapta's realm, oh yes her newest flaw brought a massive grin to his face. *Heartbreak* , something all mortals feel but Entrapta's was deliciously fresh and raw which made her world of torment all the worse for her and all the more enjoyable for himself.

Apophis cackled as he soared around, gazing upon the star-less sky. But it was not because of Mara's attempt at containing him, no, far from it. It's because in this new world, he has been ruling over everything until all the stars have faded away…well except for one. But he cared not, for he was the master of it all!

For whoever pulled that lever could be granted a reality in which their deepest desires became true. Hence why Apophis greedily took over his host and pulled the lever, to ensure his control over everything was perfect and clear. He slithered through the void

towards Gareth's realm, locked in eternal violence, fitting as that is his flaw.

He reached out and held the small bloodstained bauble of a realm in between his onyx-black claws and grinned, the god of minds and storms could hear Gareth's roars of anger and frustration as he no doubt was slaughtering countless foes that would never truly end. Apophis gave it a little rattle before letting it drift away in the void, he let out a low cackle as it did so.

"Ah, if only my dear Father could've seen me now! How his most despised child managed to usurp him in every possible way! I am the ruler of all who breathes! Of all who dare to exist!" Apophis cackled wickedly as he spread his claws out, basking in the misery of so many people. From all kinds of worlds, from all kinds of lives. All united under one thing, their suffering. Apophis took it all in, inhaling it like it was a precious aromatic gas.

Apophis then floated upwards towards a large crown composed of cruel spiked chains and the crystal prisons of his siblings. Apophis gently placed it upon his head and laughed more into the void. A joy that no mortal can truly comprehend nor could they ever understand, for Apophis has gotten everything he had ever desired.

Everything Was Perfect…for him

Adora was not spared from Apophis' foul reality, but she didn't realize it yet. Adora awoke in a strange place, it looked like a volcano, she could easily hear the bubbling of lava and the heat of

fire all around her. She coughed a few times as her eyes stung from the smoke, she lifted her head to see two crumbling pathways that lead from her platform.

Adora looked to see Glimmer and Bow on one platform and Gareth and Catra on another. Both of them were calling out to her. Adora realized she had to choose "fuck! Hang on!" Adora said as she struggled to think of where to go.

But it was too late and they both crumbled into the pit, causing Adora to scream and then she awoke again to the same scenario. Again and again, no matter what she did the outcome was the same.

By the 31st cycle, she just sat there in hopelessness until a voice reached out to her. Adora turned her head to see a red-headed figure in the garb of She-Ra and wielding the sword of protection. Adora had to shield her eyes for a second. "Who…who are you?" Adora asked softly as time itself seemed to slow.

"I am Padme, the first She-Ra of the Gods. everything is in danger, Apophis is in control, we need you. Your friends and loved ones need you" Padme explained gently as Adora took it all in. Apophis was the one who possessed Gareth like a puppet and pulled the lever, putting them into this hell.

Adora nodded and straightened her back like a true soldier, and looked at Padme as she handed the sword to her. Adora nodded towards Padme as she vanished into nothing. Adora then raised her sword up above her head as a screech was heard around her, the very fabric of her prison became corrupted and warped as if angry that Adora was trying to be freed.

“For the Honor…of Grayskull” Adora said, and as light filled her vision, she smiled and did not black out. The sound of Glass shattering was heard and she blinked to see that she was on an immense floating rock with the realms containing everyone she ever knew surrounding her.

A low growl of shock and surprise echoed through the void around her, Adora looked up to see Apophis glowering down at her. Adora couldn’t help but feel somewhat cocky, so she extended her hand to the 3rd Lord of Creation…and flipped him the bird.

Chapter 15: Dark Freedoms

Chapter 15

Dark Freedoms

"HOW DID YOU GET FREE FROM YOUR PRISON!?! HOW THE FUCK DID YOU GET YOUR SWORD?!" Apophis angrily protested in sheer godly outrage as Adora smirked and placed her sword on her shoulder, also trying to figure out a plan how to stop him but *also* she is finding this extremely entertaining. "I don't know you overgrown golden pasta noodle." Adora said with a glare but also a cocky grin "you're the god of minds? Maybe you could guess?"

"OH YOU THINK YOU'RE CUTE?!" Apophis snarled as his body became wreathed in golden lightning which arced around the very void around them. Adora exhaled slowly through her nostrils and slammed the blade of her sword into the ground "Bitch, i'm adorable" Adora said as Apophis' eye twitch. Upon delivery of that line, Apophis unhinged his snake-jaw and unleashed a flood of golden lightning at her.

Adora dodged the attack and began racing around large tracts of floating rocks, trying to reach any of the realms but Apophis was relentless and began creating a massive hurricane to whip up the ground around her, Adora kept running but occasionally she would float upwards enough to give her a brief moment of weightlessness before she landed back down onto the ground.

Apophis sailed over her, clearly to reach for something, Adora took the opportunity and swung with all of her strength and channeling

energy to blade to cut open a massive gash into his underbelly causing the snake god to scream in pain and a flood of black blood to pour over Adora.

The blood was thick and oily, and it felt like being pricked by hundreds of static shocks. Adora had to shake the blood from herself while trying to make sure the blood didn't get into her eyes, she saw that Apophis held 3 of the realms in one of his claws, he clenched his fist slightly, as the sound of glass shattering was heard all around Adora.

Apophis threw the realms at Adora and they began to glow brightly with escaping energy, but they seemed to have missed her. Adora turned to see they had surrounded her, cracking apart like horrid lovecraftian eggs. The one to Adora's left cracked apart to reveal a corrupted Catra, her body a horrid corruption of black and purple energy where her very bones were exposed.

The realm to her right cracked apart to reveal a corrupted Gareth, whose pale blue skin and fleshy exposed skull rattled open in a jaw opened maw and a rattling scream. His armor and body was covered in blood and gore of all kinds. Adora felt her skin crawl as she looked over her shoulder to see that the realm behind her cracked open to reveal a corrupted Angella, resembling a twisted mockery of her former self.

"Kill her" Apophis snarled to these corrupted minions. "And make it slow" he added as the corrupted began to snarl and charge at Adora. Adora began to run like hell, not wanting to fight them, even if they were not in their right mind.

“YOU ABANDONED US! THIS IS ALL YOUR FAULT!” the corrupted Catra roared, the pitch of her voice being tuned violently up and down. Adora kept running and didn’t pay attention to what the other two abominations had to say.

When Adora saw a realm within reach, she jumped all the way and managed to enter it with a well placed slash of her sword. While inside the realm, Adora could see that it looked like a warped version of Entrapta’s room, with every inch of the wall covered in posters of happier memories revolving around Entrapta and Hordak.

Entrapta looked up at Adora and then looked away “Adora.” Entrapta said softly, tears rolling down the rim of her mask, she sounded absolutely heartbroken. “He..he didn’t listen” Entrapta muttered softly, Adora knelt in front of Entrapta. “And you…you left me” Entrapta turned her head to Adora, hints of anger bubbling up in her voice.

“I know I did and I'm sorry Entrapta. We can fix this…just tell me how” Adora said softly, to which Entrapta looked at the floor for a few seconds. “Reality will crumble and be destroyed, unless the catalyst is brought into the center of this crisis” Entrapta explained

Adora looked at her own sword “the sword? But…where do I put it?” Adora asked Entrapta. To which Entrapta looked up at Adora. “Apophis, more specifically his head. Ram it in there and we’ll be returned to our reality. But whoever puts the sword into his head, will be trapped in between realities…a fate worse than death” Entrapta said softly as Adora stood up and began to walk.

"And Adora… *I don't forgive you* " Entrapta said in a mixture of hate, sadness and anger. Adora felt a tear rolled down her cheek as she hopped out of the realm and onto the cold hard ground. Adora looked at the corrupted three but her train of thought was interrupted by a cataclysmic thundercrack, Adora looked behind her to see a blast of Golden Lightning had destroyed Entrapta's realm.

"I never liked that nerdy candy-haired etherian anyways" Apophis snarled angrily. Before Adora could retort, she felt a force impact her and carry her into a floating piece of rock. When Adora opened her eyes she realized it was an ancient ruin of Brightmoon…more specifically it was Glimmer's room.

The force she felt hit into her was the corrupted Angella who was now looking at her surroundings, a large blade fell out of the corrupted Angella's hands and she looked over her shoulder at Adora. "Adora?" she said, her voice filled with regret and horror.

Chapter 16: A Mother's Sacrifice

Chapter 16

A Mother's Sacrifice

After a brief moment of consolation and heartache, Adora used her healing magic to the best of her abilities to ensure Angella had her mind safe and secured. They sat there in the ruins of this once treasured room, discussing their possible plan.

"So whoever uses the sword to kill Apophis…restores reality" Angella started "and gets stuck with him in between universes" Adora finished as they sat there together. After a moment or two of silence "sooo that's the plan" Adora muttered softly "we'll try and fight the corrupted Catra and Gareth to draw Apophis' attention and when he gets close enough I'll stab him in his damn head" Adora said, slamming her fist into her open palm.

Angella seemed reprehensive of the idea but seemed on board with it regardless, Adora nodded as she got up and shouldered her sword. Angella got behind Adora and carried her away and towards Apophis and his two corrupted slaves.

"Angella! Well…" Apophis' voice trailed off as he saw Adora easily drop from Angella's grasp and drop punched the corrupted Gareth into the ground. Apophis snarled angrily "OH YOU MOTHERFUCKERS!!!" Apophis roared in sheer frustrated fury and unleashed a hurricane of titanic proportions as his blasts were a frenzied barrage that Angella gracefully ducked and weaved through.

Adora elbowed Catra in the gut and kicked her away before Gareth punched her in the face and used his axe on her shoulder, causing her to cry out. "You left us TRAITOR!" Gareth snarled with utter disgust and hatred evident in his voice, Adora forced the axe out of her shoulder as Catra jumped onto her back, tugged at her hair and forced her to stumble backwards, falling onto the ground.

"We loved you and you LEFT US!" Catra hissed like a feral animal and clawed her face. Adora kicked Gareth back before standing up and pushing Catra onto the ground, she didn't want to hurt them. She wasn't sure if they died here, they died in reality.

For all she knew, Entrapta was gone forever and Adora didn't want that to happen to her surrogate siblings. But it was getting more and more difficult to not hurt them, they were holding her back from trying to save everyone! They were trying to hold her back from saving Etheria.

Adora kept punching and hitting as thunder and lightning roared around them. But unlike her, and indeed She-Ra, these corrupted siblings were relentless and more like inexhaustible undead monsters than actual living people.

"STOP IT!! STOP!!" Adora cried out but the corrupted siblings only laughed. Adora clenched her teeth in sheer anger and hatred before, out of sheer frustration, she brought her sword down on Gareth and flung him over the edge and into the void. Adora felt a sinking sensation in her gut when she did it.

Catra lunged angrily and nearly took them both off the edge but Adora stumbled around and through Catra onto the ground. Tears stained both of their faces as they stood off, Adora felt…

exhaustion and grief magnify into her soul. It was overwhelming and Adora fell to her knees, she couldn't understand this level of sorrow…she shot her head up and looked at Apophis.

Apophis' eyes were glowing and Adora came to a horrific realization that Apophis was focused on amplifying her emotional guilt and sorrow to insane heights. Adora began to panic as she realized what Apophis was trying to drive Adora towards as her body was already angling the sword for her own neck.

That was until Adora couldn't feel the sword anymore, she looked over to Angella. "Angella??" Adora called out, already feeling more like herself again. "Adora, Etheria needs you more than it needs me. But…please promise me something. You'll give Glimmer a happy life won't you?" Angella said softly. Adora nodded as she reverted to her normal self, the corrupted Catra was creating a monstrous blade from her own body as Apophis was charging up a cataclysmic blast.

"I will, try to make it back to us okay?" Adora said, tears welling up in her eyes. Angella nodded, they both knew that…perhaps it was meant to be this way. "I will" Angella said as she began to soar towards Apophis. Apophis snarled angrily in tune with Catra's own hateful hiss.

"You just couldn't resist being the fucking hero huh Adora?" the corrupted Catra snarled angrily as she held her sword in the palm of her hand. "You could've joined us! But we stayed loyal! You didn't!"

"You are a mere queen of peasants! Of mere rats! No one will remember you! I will live on in Eternity, what you do here will never accomplish anything! I AM THE FIRES OF THE MIND!! THE

STORMS OF HATE!!” Apophis boldly declared, still charging up his blast. “I SHALL RULE OVER ALL!”

There was a brief moment of silence. Both queen and warrior took a deep breath and exhaled, before responding.

“ ***YOU MADE YOUR CHOICE! NOW LIVE WITH IT!!*** ” Adora and Angella yelled in perfect sync as Angella’s stab with the sword of protection connected with Apophis’ skull and Adora’s punch connected with Catra’s jaw. A blast occurred that was so loud that it shook the very fabric of reality all around them. A third and final flash of light occurred.

Adora, in her She-Ra form, had punched Gareth so hard that he was flung through a damn wall. The usual golden light of his crystal rapidly faded, Gareth sat up in confusion before seeing Adora standing there with a piercing and hateful glare that dug right into his soul.

“KILL HE-” Hordak couldn’t even get the command in before he got kneed so hard in the stomach by Adora that a miniature sonic boom echoed throughout the entire room. Adora walked away casually, ripping apart anyone or anything that got in her way and easily freed her friends.

In the days that followed the Portal Incident…Gareth would realize that Apophis no longer spoke to him in his head. In fact…it felt like he was gone entirely. Around that same time, the horde received word that Queen Angella had completely vanished from Etheria.

Chapter 17: Crimson Revolution

Chapter 17

Crimson Revolution

Hordak could barely comprehend what was going on. It had been a week since the portal incident, he didn't realize that his days had reached zero. All across the Fright Zone, red armored warriors attacked the Horde loyalists with sheer brutality as the gates were overwhelmed by an unyielding flood of warriors from the crimson wastes.

Gareth was adorned in fearsome armor, red and spiked, adorned with nordic runes. His spiked pauldrons were imposing, like the flamethrower mounted on his right shoulder. His black and red cape bore the sigil of a four horned ram skull, this same sigil was emblazoned on his chest piece, his spiked and clawed gauntlets gave him a more bestial effect coupled with his left gauntlet that possessed a retractable armblade that added to this fear factor. The elbow portions of the armor are bare, which gave him a barbaric appearance.

Catra was adorned in elegantly terrifying leather armor, asymmetrical sleeves that end in fingerless gloves. A bit of cleavage is shown, on the front chest piece bore the same four horned ram skull as Gareth's cape. Her crown bears horns like a demon and her leg armor is completed with armored boots.

The two were unstoppable as they cleaved their way into the heart of the Fright Zone. Gareth grabbed a horde loyalist by the

throat and snapped it like a twig while Catra jumped off him and used her snake sword to slash open the throats of several more loyalists and then drove her leg into another loyalist's head which cracked like an egg.

"RIP AND TEAR!!!" Catra and Gareth yelled and the armies at her and Gareth's command responded "UNTIL IT'S DONE!!" They roared with thunderous vigor. Gareth charged forth and ripped into more loyalists, a force captain stepped forth with some other troops armed with rifles. "You're dead you fu-" the force captain was stopped when Scorpia blew his head clean off with a heavy blaster before blasting the other loyalist troops "come on! Hordak's throne is this way!" Scorpia yelled.

Gareth and Catra ran on ahead, the trio was seen fighting multiple soldiers and clearly winning. Gareth charged up a blast of Golden Lightning and fired it off at the gate to Hordak's throne room. The electrical energy blasted the gate off its hinges, Gareth stepped forward and unsheathed his axe. Catra stood by his side as Scorpia went off to assist the revolution as it continued to rampage.

The armies yelled in a primal chant "NO RETREAT NO SURRENDER!! FIGHT ON TO THE DEATH" this was muffled in this throne room but it was no less vigorous. The loyalists Were outnumbered by two armies that were completely intent on ripping them apart. It was clear that the Horde's final hours were at hand,

Hordak sat at his throne "I should have killed you two and Adora when you were brats. I know you were responsible for the

message being deleted...the one I intended to send to Prime! You have ruined everything!" Hordak roared "I'll-I'll have your heads!"

Gareth and Catra exchanged glances before looking at Hordak "no, we'll have your throne" Gareth said with a happy grin, his heart pounded with sheer excitement. Hordak stood up from his throne and put on his arm cannon and approached them. Gareth charged forward and swung Bloodbane at Hordak.

Hordak had barely enough time to dodge the swing but got a vicious claw swipe from Catra, causing Hordak to stumble and blindly fire his cannon. Catra kicked him in the back of his head, causing Hordak to fire once more and blast the ceiling with a rapturous explosion.

Gareth grinned as he punched Hordak in the stomach, the sounds of ribs cracking made Gareth even more confident. Catra climbed up the rafters as Hordak blasted Gareth in the shoulder causing his left pauldron to be blasted off.

"Now then, it's time I end your madness, son of Skeletor" Hordak said with a growl. Gareth simply shrugged and cockily chuckled "you sure about that?" He mused as he watched Catra get into position, Hordak began to charge his cannon. Catra dropped down like the hammer of an angry god, driving her fist into Hordak's Jaw and her leg down on his arm cannon which shattered it like glass.

Hordak didn't have time to react fully before Gareth's armblade extended and rammed itself into Hordak's stomach, spilling green

blood onto the ground. Gareth leaned forward and grinned from ear to ear "it's over" he said before sheathing it. Hordak collapsed onto his back and coughed up blood, with a dosage of magical lightning, Gareth sealed up his wound which prevented him from dying right then and there.

"I'm not going to kill you, not for my sake. But for Entrapta's sake. She cares for you Hordak, so you are alive as long as she commands it. If she comes back and wants you dead, you'll die. If she wants you to live? You'll live. You best pray to your precious Prime that Entrapta decides to forgive you" Gareth said with a low growl.

More of Gareth's warriors rushed in being led by Scorpia, the fighting has died down and victory over the fright zone has been confirmed, those few Horde loyalists who did not die fled away from the Fright Zone. The trio also joined in the scene, seeing that they were indeed victorious. Catra and Gareth approached the throne as warriors grabbed Hordak and dragged out of the room. Gareth observed his feline wife drag her hand across the armrest "I guess we're gonna have to share huh? At least for now" Catra said with a smile before locking her eyes onto Gareth's.

The young man nodded before looking at the gathering of warriors before him. "We have just one more thing to do everyone. One last mission before we can fully establish ourselves as a new kingdom." Gareth explained. Immediately, Scorpia raised her arm and shouted "we need Entrapta back!". Gareth pointed at Scorpia and smirked "damn straight! We know she's on Beast island and that's where we are going to get her!"

Catra stepped forward and stood next to her husband “lock and load! We are gonna rescue Entrapta!” She yelled raising her fist into the air and the soldiers in the throne room cheered wildly.

Chapter 18: Saving Entrapta

Chapter 18

Saving Entrapta

Entrapta was barely keeping it together, her heart was broken and she was separated from her friends. Her old welding mask was replaced from one made from the severed head of a mantis-like creature, the victim of a darker side of her.

This same side emerged when she talked to the rebels all that time ago. Entrapta sat next to the campfire she made examining a bracelet. The bracelet was a handmade gift from Hordak before Gareth and the others went to the Crimson Wastes. Entrapta sighed as she held the bracelet close to her heart, her brief moment of peace was interrupted by the distant roar of gunfire.

Entrapta cautiously made her way towards the sounds, it was obvious that the local wildlife was agitated by the hostile presence. Entrapta looked to a nearby ledge above her and saw the only other person on this island, Micah.

Micah was a curious being, his old garbs led Entrapta to believe that he was from Brightmoon. He didn't speak much about his past, but he certainly had a lot of knowledge about the island and helped her survive with that very knowledge. "Micah! Any ideas about what's going on?" Entrapta asked him, he didn't respond for a few moments as he adjusted his old spyglass

“Looks like the island is being invaded.” He muttered without looking at her. Entrapta gasped as her eyes sparkled “we’re being rescued!” She exclaimed. Micah furrowed his brow “I don’t know, we should keep our heads down, these guys don’t look friendly” he explained to her.

Entrapta pouted and looked down “well they COULD be here to rescue us. We should go up to them and greet them!” She inquired. Micah shook his head in refusal “No way, I am not going to get killed by some raiders. The island is constantly getting invaded by guys going trophy hunts or treasures. I still have a wife and daughter to get back to.” Micah stated coldly, Entrapta slumped a little as she sighed.

Another sudden roar of gunfire caused Entrapta to jump a bit in surprise, but nonetheless went back to the campfire. Entrapta tended to the fire that crackled at her feet. She must have passed out some point as it was sundown, however that wasn’t the source of her panic. It was the sound of something that was breaking down the barricades she had set up.

Entrapta stood up, trembling, and grabbed her makeshift club tightly. Her breathing was rapid and shaky as she lowered her mask, the barricade cracked more before breaking apart. Entrapta shut her eyes and swung her club blindly, she felt it struck something with a crack.

Entrapta then became aware of a groan of pain. The princess of Dyrll opened her eyes and saw Gareth holding the side of his head. “Oh my gosh! Gareth, I'm so sorry!!” She apologized, letting go of her club which thudded onto the ground, and hugging her close friend.

Gareth chuckled as his head bled a bit. “Hey it’s okay, that was a hell of a blow!” He said in his usual carefree nature. “I’m just glad you’re okay” Gareth mused with a smile as Entrapta bandaged his head. “What are you doing here!?” Entrapta exclaimed, still riding the wave of adrenaline that was coursing through her veins

“heh, we came for you! Me and Catra overthrew Hordak, our kingdom is gonna be founded but we need you, I need you. So what do you say?” Gareth said, maintaining his smile. Entrapta felt tears well up in her eyes and she hugged him. “Of course! Best friend squad for life!” Entrapta yelled excitedly.

Gareth nodded and stood up. “Well let’s go! This island gives me the creeps.” He admitted as Entrapta nodded. Gareth cleaves his way through the vines. It was curious how they were akin to cables and they gave Entrapta the idea to return to this place one day.

Gareth’s warriors had created a beachhead on the shores of Beast Island, many of the warriors that came back from the island’s hellish jungles were gravely injured. Catra watched as Gareth came out of the jungle with Entrapta, her eyes widened in joy.

“Entrapta!!” Catra yelled moments before Entrapta ran up and hugged Her, causing Catra to tense up a bit. “Yoooouuu get a pass” Catra said slowly before Entrapta let go of her. Gareth became aware of a commotion caused by a bearded man being carried by a group of warriors.

“Sir! We found this man spying on us.” One of the warriors reported. Upon seeing the bearded man, Entrapta immediately spoke up “Micah!” She shouted which got Gareth and Catra exchanging looks before looking at the man in question.

“As in the King of brightmoon?” Catra asked, which got a shock out of Entrapta. Gareth kept his eyes on Micah and an idea crossed his mind, “Take him with us and give him a nice cozy cell.” He ordered the warriors, he turned to look at a very surprised Entrapta.

Gareth leaned in close to Entrapta “if he is anything close to what Shadow Weaver described, then we need him on our side and not on the Rebel’s side.” He whispered, Entrapta found herself agreeing with this line of logic.

After a few more hours of waiting, Gareth stood looking into the Jungle. Catra approached him “no one else is gonna come out, i’m sorry hun.” Catra said, holding his hand. Gareth let out a mournful sigh “I...don’t want to leave those warriors behind” Gareth said, referring to the squad that have yet to return.

It took Gareth a few more moments before he was willing to board the last ship. Him and Catra shared a cabin on this ship, Gareth would watch through the windows as the island grew smaller and smaller in the distance, illuminated by the cold indifference of the moons.

Gareth quietly laid down next to Catra, he won’t let those sacrifices be in vain. In her own Cabin, Entrapta looked at a

picture of herself and Hordak. The picture showed them to be so happy. But Entrapta could only feel sadness and anger, she went to rip up the photo but…she couldn't bring herself to do so.

Hordak's obsession caused her misery, but…she knew she could find herself to forgive him. The first thing she's going to do is make sure Hordak is her lab assistant. She could convince Gareth to do so, she knew she could. Though…could Hordak forgive himself? That was another question altogether.

Entrapta collapses onto her ship bed, glaring at the ceiling both Hordak and the Rebels have both betrayed her...but not her true friends. They braved beast island just to save her, this thought brought her comfort. Her true home was with the new kingdom, to be by Hordak's side…or rather to have him by her side. But the Rebels? Oh…oh they *will* pay.

Chapter 19: Ziadroth

Chapter 19

Ziadroth

It’s been 3 years since Entrapta was rescued. Thanks to the massive population that came from the Crimson Wastes and Entrapta’s scientific prowess, the Fright Zone was transformed into a massive fortress city, with factories mass producing all kinds of technologies, from guns to automobiles. Street lights illuminate the metal roads and ration bars were replaced with actual meals.

Farms that exist within the city walls and its mines exploit the immense resources that the Fright Zone has barely utilized. They became a megacity, expanding towards the east, making their expansion barely noticeable to their enemies. Not that it mattered as Queen Glimmer and Queen Adora were focused on trying to heal after the Horde.

They took the 3 years to re-establish the kingdoms and form the Coalition Of Etheria, which bore the sigil of a white wolf head adorned with blue flames. The megacity of Ziadroth dwarfed the Fright Zone, whose bones formed the heart of this new warrior nation. It stretched for kilometres and reached the eastern coast of the continent which made this new Ziadroth a rival naval power to Salineas, who ruled the western coast.

The black flags of this militant nation bore the blood red sigil of a four horned ram skull. Gareth and Catra rule as Emperor and

Empress, Entrapta is the royal scientist and forgemaster who designs Ziadroth's tech from weapons to droids.

Scorpia is the right hand of the emperor who, in her spare time, also sings in the national radio where her singing is heard by countless Ziadroth citizens. Fulfilling one of her dreams that she never could in the horde.

The trio serve as the secret agents of the emperor, who partake in dangerous missions for the royal family. Gareth ensured that the Viking culture that Revna taught him was the primary culture of Ziadroth. Temples to the Norse gods are seen throughout the megacity.

At the heart of Ziadroth, Gareth and Catra sat upon their thrones, wearing their royal garb. Entrapta approached the two, adjusting her uniform and smirked. Hordak was by her side, but he was silent and respectful. "Gareth, Catra. We are all ready for the next step! Our declaration is loaded up onto the speaker bots and are ready for deployment." Entrapta explained with confidence etched onto her voice.

Gareth and Catra looked at each other before nodding. "Deploy them. It's time to show this world what the new kingdom on the block is all about" Catra said with a cocky grin. Entrapta walked off, eagerness was dancing in her eyes.

Soon thousands of orb-shaped robots swarmed out of Ziadroth and spread its declaration of Ziadroth in Gareth's voice to every corner of the continent.

“Many long years ago, like a plague, the Horde arrived. Etherians grew weak and cowardly, only a shadow of what they once were. There were those who had strength to oppose the Horde, strength that was in the few.

Those few were rejected until it was too late, a rebellion formed in a state unfit to be a proper threat. It took a She-Ra to ensure that these rebels would win time and time again, but they too have grown complacent in their victories. Now a new force has risen on Etheria, a new Kingdom, one that understands the values of Strength, freedom and loyalty. One that has risen from the ashes of the Horde like a bloodstained phoenix. We have come to put Etheria on a proper course, War is a natural stare for humans. It unites them, and makes them strong against any force.

War shall be the anvil in which we reforge etherians into something new and greater. This will be an age of fire and glory, and when it concludes all shall fly our banner. Prepare yourself Etheria, Ziadroth has arrived,

Rip and tear, until it’s done.”

When the entire continent heard this declaration, all of its denizens. Both Coalition and not, set their eyes upon Ziadroth and were completely consumed with fear. Glimmer gripped her throne’s armrests, “that bastard” Adora muttered in shock. Brightmoon’s General stepped forward “my queens, what do we do?” The general asked still trembling from the chilling message,

Glimmer looked at the crowd in her courtroom, she closed ger eyes and thought before she responded. “Prepare for war” she responded coldly. The courtroom erupted in panicked murmurs but soon accepted this fate.

Adora sighed and patted Glimmer’s hand “we’ll get through this” she said with a comforting smile. Glimmer gently touched her own belly “the three of us?” She asked to which Adora nodded “yeah, the three of us” Adora answered with a confident nod.

Bow stood by them but his mind was on other things. What kind of nightmares will this give him? What kind of death will this unleash upon the world? Bow walked outside and gazed over the city from a balcony. He felt the wind brush past his skin. Swift wind landed next to him “soo, you heard that?” He asked Bow. The young archer didn’t look at Swift Wind but he nodded “yep...I think this war is gonna be the end of us. We should’ve tried a bit harder…” Bow said “take the opportunity when we had the chance” he added,

Swift Wind shook his head in disagreement “we’re gonna win in the end...right?” He said, a bit offput by Bow’s silence. Bow smiled gently and patted Swift Wind’s head “sure we are” he lied, as he didn’t want to burden Swift Wind. The steed flew off as Bow looked up at the night sky.

In the past it was a simple black, featureless sky. But since the portal incident, the night sky was now an immense colorful array of the universe. It didn’t bring any comfort to Bow, it felt like this immense yawning universe was eager to swallow the world whole.

Bow always felt something was watching them and it’s...hungry.

Epilogue: Dawn of War

Epilogue

Dawn of War

The Dark Wind Tavern was at the crossroads between Plumera and the Brightmoon town of Dimitrescu. It’s been a few days since the declaration of Ziadroth and as such the tavern was full of activity. A scarred woman in the clothes of a wandering traveller was having a simple meal with a tankard of ale, her scarf kept her cozy as the thunder storm raged on outside.

The fireplace crackled gently among the commotion, but she didn't pay any attention to the commotion. She looked at the newstable on her table, talking about the possibility of war with Ziadroth. She exhaled gently from her nose and tapped her fingers around the warm tankard before taking a sip of the spiced ale.

She was glad no one could identify her, otherwise they would be at her throat. Shadow Weaver gently adjusted her scarf as she pondered on what to do next. Adora was queen of Brightmoon and her two other children were the rulers of the biggest war machine on the planet.

Not a lot of options were left, seeing the scared patrons, they hadn’t witnessed a true war and no one had seen the type of war Ziadroth was capable of. Shadow Weaver ate a small piece of meat that was part of her basic meal, feeling the life force enter her,

As miniscule as it was compared to a runestone, it still provided enough magical sustenance to survive. Another swig of the spiced ale made her long for some decent wine. A deafening thundercrack caused some of the other patrons to start heading to their rooms and the rest to leave.

Soon it was empty except for the tavern owner. Suddenly shadow Weaver tensed up as a figure suddenly appeared in the tavern which gave the owner a bit of fright.

"Wh-where did you come fro-" was all the owner said before the figure snapped his fingers and the owner's head instantly exploded into a shower of gore. The body stood twitching for a few seconds more before hitting the floor with a sickening thud.

Shadow Weaver stood still and took in the figure's details, his staff bore a ram skull which almost seemed to grin in the flickering flames of the fireplace, his clothing obscured most of his body but Shadow Weaver could observe the blue arms of this terrifying figure.

"Ease yourself, if I wanted you dead, you would have joined this man" the figure stated before walking towards one of the tables and grabbed a chessboard and its pieces from one of the tables. "Care for some chess?" The figure asked, Shadow Weaver felt compelled to agree and the figure sat across from her.

Shadow Weaver made the first move “what brings you to this place?” She asked, trying to maintain composure. The figure made his move “simply travelling from place to place” the figure began “looking for a lost relative”

This prompted Shadow Weaver’s attention “care to describe thus relative?” She asked as she made her move. The figure nodded, the shadows obscured his face. “Young, about 22 or so, brown hair, green eyes...a scar on the bridge of his nose...a golden crystal in his chest” the figure explained, Shadow Weaver’s blood grew cold and she shuddered, the figure took notice and chuckled lowly.

The air glowed green around this figure, an ancient power that made Shadow Weaver even more afraid than anything else. She only heard mere rumors and whispers of it, the very aspect of destruction and entropy. The most powerful force in all creation… *Havoc* and this figure was so attuned to it that the very air around him radiated its reality warping might.

“Someone you know? Perhaps even raised?” He said softly, but his voice was full of evil which made Shadow Weaver even more tense. He made his move as Shadow Weaver could feel her heart best faster.

“Oh do not fret Shadow Weaver, I have no intent to interfere with this grand conflict, in fact I intend to watch the flames of war devour this world and watch my son claim it for his own” the figure declared with a low chuckle.

Shadow Weaver furrowed her brow angrily “Gareth may be many things but he isn’t a tyrant” she responded coldly. The figure leaned forward, the flames of the fire illuminated the inside of his hood, revealing that his head is nothing more than a skull with monstrous red eyes.

“He already rules the largest empire this rock has ever seen. But it matters, not what you think. The dawn of war has come, Shadow Weaver, and I wonder if you’ll be a participant or if you too will simply observe” the figure said before standing up and making the final move, getting a checkmate in that move. “Should you choose the latter, I suggest buying supplies now. War has an awful habit of causing prices to erupt” the figure chuckled and vanished in a cloud of darkness.

The figure’s presence was a projection, and nothing more. Shadow Weaver knew such an ability well, but usually such projections are weak and ghostly in appearance. The fact a mere projection was able to be perfectly manifested and easily kill a man with a mere snap of his fingers indicated that this being was more powerful than any living magic user on Etheria and indeed… even the universe.

Shadow Weaver knew that this was Skeletor. The only being capable of such immense and powerful magic and Gareth’s father. Shadow Weaver wondered if Gareth’s mother was also alive, given how Skeletor seemed to be aware of his son’s presence…she could only guess that he would know shortly of his bride’s fate.

Shadow Weaver sat there stunned for a few moments before looking at the newsletter still at her table, she drank the last of her ale and grabbed her gear. Leaving a purse of coins at the bar,

staring at the headless corpse of the owner for a few moments before heading out of the tavern and making her way to Brightmoon.

Shadow Weaver lifted her scarf as the thunderclouds roared around her. A New War is coming...in all its glory and all its horror.

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